SYNTAX AND SEMANTICS INTERFACE OF ENGLISH AND IGBO ELLIPTICAL STRUCTURES

BY

UMEH, UDUMA UDUMA

Matric No: 225138

BA English (ABSU)

A PROJECT IN THE DEPARTMENT OF ENGLISH SUBMITTED TO THE FACULTY OF ARTS, UNIVERSITY OF IBADAN IN PARTIAL FULFILMENT OF THE REQUIREMENTS FOR THE DEGREE OF MASTER OF ARTS IN ENGLISH LANGUAGE

MARCH, 2023

ABSTRACT

Nigeria's linguistic landscape is a pluralistic one. Indigenous languages like Igbo and others coexist with English. With English being the language of education, interferences from these indigenous languages are inevitable. Hence, there is need for examinations of English and these indigenous languages. Such examination will properly characterize the features attested in the languages with their variations and hence, facilitate learning. Existing studies on Igbo, for example, have paid attention to characterize some syntactic features like morphology, morphosyntax, inflection and so on. Exploration into elliptical structures in both languages is lacking even though language users find elliptical structures as faster and more convenient ways of speaking. This work, therefore, compares and contrasts elliptical structures in English and Igbo with the intention of identifying and syntactically describing their licensing conditions as well as predicting possible learning difficulties that Igbo learners of English may encounter.

Merchant's E-Feature provided within the architectural framework of the Minimalist Program was adopted as the theoretical framework to show the deletion process of elliptical structures in both languages. Data on English were collected from various books and publications like Lobeck (1995), Kester (1996) Merchants (2001) Johnson (2004) and Gengel (2007). The variety of Igbo examined is the Standard Igbo and data were structures extracted through guided oral interviews from six purposively selected Igbo speakers in Abia State. The data were descriptively analysed.

English and Igbo attested VP-ellipsis, Fragment ellipsis and NP ellipsis. Igbo, however, shows some variations in the licensing conditions in VP ellipsis. Igbo, being an agglutinative language in some respects, conflates certain linguistic materials like auxiliaries, modals, and discourse linkers in an obligatory manner. These materials bear important information and are merged and hosted on T head where they are spelled out. The remaining materials in the VP domain get checked and deleted. The deletion of the items merged and hosted together with the auxiliary that should have licensed their deletion is covert. In the English data, the auxiliary is independently hosted on the T head where it parses the deletion of the materials or constituents in the VP domain. Fragmentary utterances are also attested in both languages. Fragmentary utterances show some connectivity effects like morphological case marking and binding with their full sentential counterparts. This connectivity effects argues that there are actually lexical items in the fragment answers that are syntactically dependent on the context. Violations of these dependency conditions produce ungrammaticality. Determiners or modifiers like demonstratives, possessives, numerals and quantifiers license deletion of their NP complements. However, Igbo shows a variation in head directionality. Some DPs are head-initial while others are head-final. This affects the deletion process of NPs. Finally, while most quantifiers can license deletion, *every* and *no* cannot in English and *niile* cannot in Igbo.

While VP ellipsis, NP ellipsis and fragment ellipsis are common features attested in both languages, obligatory verb and auxiliary conflation, head directionality and divergence in some remnant modifier condition are variations observed in Igbo. Proper pedagogic attention will reduce errors and facilitate learning.

Key words: elliptical structures, licensing conditions, English, Igbo

Word Count: 496

ACKNOWLEGDEMENTS

I express my profound gratitude to God almighty, the maker of life and the giver of destinies who saw me worthy to start and complete this program.

I am also sincerely grateful to my supervisor, Prof. M.T. Lamidi, for painstakingly providing the insightful suggestions, thorough corrections and constructive criticisms that guided this research. I thank him for his resolute efforts towards ensuring that the right thing was done in this work. Thank you and God bless you profusely, Sir. I am also deeply grateful to Dr Nweya of the Department of Linguistics, University of Ibadan. You are one of the best parts of my Ibadan story. Thank you for your inputs and wise counsels. To Prof. Igboanusi, God bless you for asking me to see Dr Nweya.

I am thankful too to all my lecturers in the Department of English, University of Ibadan for the academically rich and life-changing teaching and seminar presentation sessions I had with them in the course of the program. I pray to never recover from the positive impacts.

To Mamaa, thank you for always being there and encouraging me when it looked like I was stuck with the research. My siblings were wonderful during my stay at Ibadan. Thank you Nkasi and Monday. I made wonderful friends during this program: Tolu, Tessy, Godwin, Bernard, Ifeoluwa, Ayo, Tossin, Victor and so many others that I lack the space to mention. I am full of thanks to God for bringing you people my way. The future holds great things for us.

DEDICATION

For being determined not to give up on anything even when there are compelling reasons to, I dedicate this work to myself. I'll keep going. With faith and hope, I will.

CERTIFICATION

I certify that this research was carried out by **UMEH, UDUMA UDUMA** in the Department of English, University of Ibadan under my supervision.

……………………………………………….

Supervisor

Professor M.T. Lamidi

BA, MA, PhD (Ibadan)

Department of English

University of Ibadan,

Ibadan, Nigeria

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Title page	i
Abstract	ii
Acknowledgements	iii
Dedication	iv
Certification	v
Table of contents	vi
List of figures	x
Chapter One: Introduction	
1.0. Background to the study	1
1.1 Brief history of the English language	3
1.2. The linguistic situation of Nigeria	7
1.2.1. Implantation of English in Nigeria	7
1.2.2. The status of English in Nigeria and its sociolinguistic consequences	9
1.2.3. Bilingualism	12
1.3. The Igbo Language	12
1.4. Contrastive analysis	16
1.4.1. Contrastive analysis hypothesis	17
1.5. Statement of the problem	18
1.6. Aim and objectives	19
1.7. Research questions	19
1.8. Scope of the study	20
1.9. Significance of the study	20

1.10. Justification of the study 21

1.11. Summary 21

Chapter Two: Literature review and theoretical framework

2.0. Introduction 23

2.1. Literature review 23

2.1.2. Conceptual review 23

2.1.2.1. Definition and general insight into the ellipsis phenomenon 23

2.1.2.2. Ellipsis in generative syntax 26

2.1.2.3. Types of ellipsis in generative syntax selected for the study 27

2.1.2.4. Syntax and semantics debate on ellipsis licensing 29

2.1.3. Empirical studies on the ellipsis phenomenon 35

2.2. Theoretical framework 38

2.2.1. The Minimalist Program 38

2.2.1.1. Merchant's theoretical assumption on ellipsis licensing within the MP 43

2.2.1.1.1. PF deletion process 43

2.2.1.1.2. The E-Feature 43

2.2.1.1.3. The E-Feature and focus 47

2.3. Justification of the theoretical framework 48

2.4. Summary 48

Chapter Three: Methodology

3.1. Introduction 50

3.2. Research design 50

3.3. Study area 50

3.4. Study population 51

3.5. Population sample 51

3.6. Research instrument 51

3.7. Method of data collection 52

3.8. Method of data analysis 53

3.9. Summary 53

Chapter Four: VP ellipsis, Fragment ellipsis and NP ellipsis in English and Igbo

4.0. Introduction 54

4.1. VP ellipsis in English 54

4.1.2. Syntax and semantics identity in VP ellipsis 56

4.1.3. Licensing of VP ellipsis 56

4.2. VP ellipsis in Igbo 58

4.3. Contrastive statement 61

4.4. Fragment ellipsis in English 62

4.4.1. Licensing of fragment ellipsis in English 65

4.5. Fragments in Igbo 67

4.6. Contrastive statement 71

4.7. NP ellipsis in English 72

4.7.1. Licensing of NP ellipsis in English 73

4.8. NP ellipsis in Igbo 76

4.9. Contrastive statement 80

Chapter Five: Summary and conclusion

5.0. Introduction 82

5.1. Summary of the study 82

5.2. Findings 82

5.3. Hierarchy of difficulties 84

5.4. Conclusion 85

References 86

LIST OF FIGURES

Figure 1: Linguistic map showing the dialects of English in the British Isles 5

Figure 2: Germanic family tree 6

Figure 3: Map of Igbo land in Nigeria 15

Figure4: The schema for the architecture of the Minimalist Program 42

CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.0. Background to the study

Communication is an integral part of human existence and to communicate, strings of words that are encoded with meaning are assembled and put to use. Sometimes, the need to be as precise as possible in the use of these word strings arises. Most language users achieve this by cutting down the redundancies in utterances whose contexts had already been established. Users of languages across the world have pursued this by making attempts to delete some syntactic materials in their utterances especially when they believe such deletions do not affect meaning. This is called the ellipsis phenomenon. The nature and structure of elliptical structures have attracted tremendous research interests across some natural languages of the world. Some of these studies show that languages differ in the way they show the grammaticality or ungrammaticality in the construction and licensing of elliptical structures. Some of them include Kratzer (1991), Johnson (2004), Gengel (2007), Kertz (2010), Algryani (2012), Bevis (2018) and Ugorji (2019).

Many of these studies on ellipsis have been robustly engaged in different kinds of ellipsis like sluicing, VP-ellipsis, gapping, fragments, sprouting, NP-ellipsis and so on. For instance, Algryani (2012) observes that some apparent cases of sluicing are instances of pseudosluicing despite their superficial appearances as sluicing. This would follow from the fact that Libyan Arabic is a null subject language with covert copulas and non-case-marked wh-expressions. Erschler (2018:9) reports that altsluicing and Polsluicing produce what he refers to as "pseudoEnglish". Bevis, (2018) observes that IsiZulu does seem to have a type of VP ellipsis which is just like English VP-ellipsis. He also adds that sluicing and gapping are attested in IsiZulu just like most Bantu languages. Other studies have reported that sluicing, gapping and other kinds of ellipsis produce ungrammatical and unacceptable structures in some languages and grammatical or slightly acceptable structures in others. These variations that have been reported in these studies appear to be a result of the headedness principle or head parameters as obtained in Universal Grammar (UG) and hence, this present study aims at interrogating the existence of any possible variation between English and Igbo elliptical structures. Doing this will provide insight into the two components of UG: the core and the periphery, where the core includes features that are replete among languages and the periphery, the features that are peculiar to specific languages.

In searching for the principles of UG as well as Language-distinct parameters that yield variations, Kayne (2013) posits that closely-related languages should be given more comparatively syntactic attention. According to Kayne (2013:137),

> The varying difficulty of the question of "counterparts" of words (or morphemes across language feeds into the more general fact that it is easier to search for comparative syntax correlations across a set of more closely-related languages than across a set of less closely-related languages. If the languages being compared are more closely-related / more similar to one another, it is almost certain that there will be fewer variables that one has to control for, and that will therefore be greater likelihood of success in pinning down valid correlations.

Against this backdrop, the study of elliptical structures in structurally similar or different languages has dominated cross-linguistic research and has also generated debates across languages. So many of these studies have been invested in the English language and some other languages of the world. However, the contribution of Igbo in a contrastive analysis of elliptical structures with English is very little or completely lacking. Hence, this study is inspired by the need to do a comparative study of the syntactic nature of elliptical structures of English and Igbo, as well the role played by semantics in determining the licensing conditions of these elliptical structures. This is in a bid to improve the teaching and learning of English by Igbo learners of the English language. The findings will be forwarded as scholarly contributions to the cross-linguistic discourse about the ellipsis phenomenon.

This contrastive study of elliptical structures between English and indigenous Nigerian languages such as Igbo, as is the case of this present study, is also necessitated by the relationship between both languages on the linguistic landscape of Nigeria where English is a second language or a target language (henceforth L2/ TL) and Igbo, an indigenous language or first language (L1, henceforth). This bilingual relationship sometimes leads to language deficiencies. When languages come in contact, interferences or transfers are inevitable. In the case of this study, the similarities and differences in elliptical constructions in English and Igbo will be interrogated to discover possible interferences or transfers that may be occasioned by the contact between English and Igbo.

We argue, in consideration of the facts that because English is an L2 or TL and Igbo an L1 in the Igbo speaking areas under investigation in this study, interference or transfer in the usage of some ellipsis kinds like VP-ellipsis, fragments and NP ellipsis is an unavoidable phenomenon and therefore, a contrastive study of these selected elliptical structures between English and Igbo such as this study, contributes immensely in predicting and discovering possible learning difficulties that may be encountered by Igbo learners of English in the use of the aforementioned ellipsis kinds in speech and writing. Also, the study intends to track areas of similarities or differences in the ellipsis phenomenon between the two languages with a view to ensuring that necessary emphasis is laid on more effective second language teaching and learning of English. The study employs ideas from the Minimalist Program to interrogate and provide adequate descriptions and explanations for the selected English and Igbo elliptical structures. The study intends to examine which elliptical structure is licensed and which is not in the two languages. It also seeks to know how and why grammaticality or acceptability judgments are passed on these structures.

1.1. Brief History of the English Language

The history of the English language is divided into three periods: Old English, Middle English and Early Modern English. The advent of Old English began with the invasion of Britain by the three Germanic tribes in the 5th century AD. These tribes include the Angles, the Saxons and the Jutes. They crossed the North Sea from what is today Denmark and Northern Germany. At that time, the inhabitants of Britain spoke the Celtic language and most of these Celtic speakers were pushed West and North by the invaders mainly into what is now Wales, Scotland and Ireland. The Middle English began with the Norman Conquest in 1066. The end of this period is noted by the introduction of the Printing Press by William Caxton in 1476. The Early Modern English dates to the 16th century and is popular for some breakthroughs like vocabulary expansion and the Great Vowel Shift.

English is of the Indo-European Language family. These are languages that are predominantly indigenous to Europe, the Iranian plateau and the subcontinent of Northern India. Some other languages in this family are French, Portuguese, Russian, Dutch and Spanish. Today, English is one of the most widely spoken languages in the world having expanded through different forms of contacts, especially missionary activities and colonialism, from the native-speaker spheres to other parts of the world. Hence, Nigeria is one the countries that witnessed, through expansion, the implantation of English.

(Source: http://englishwithjohn.net/)

Figure 1: Linguistic map showing the dialects of English in the British Isle

GENETIC CLASSIFICATION OF ENGLISH LANGUAGE

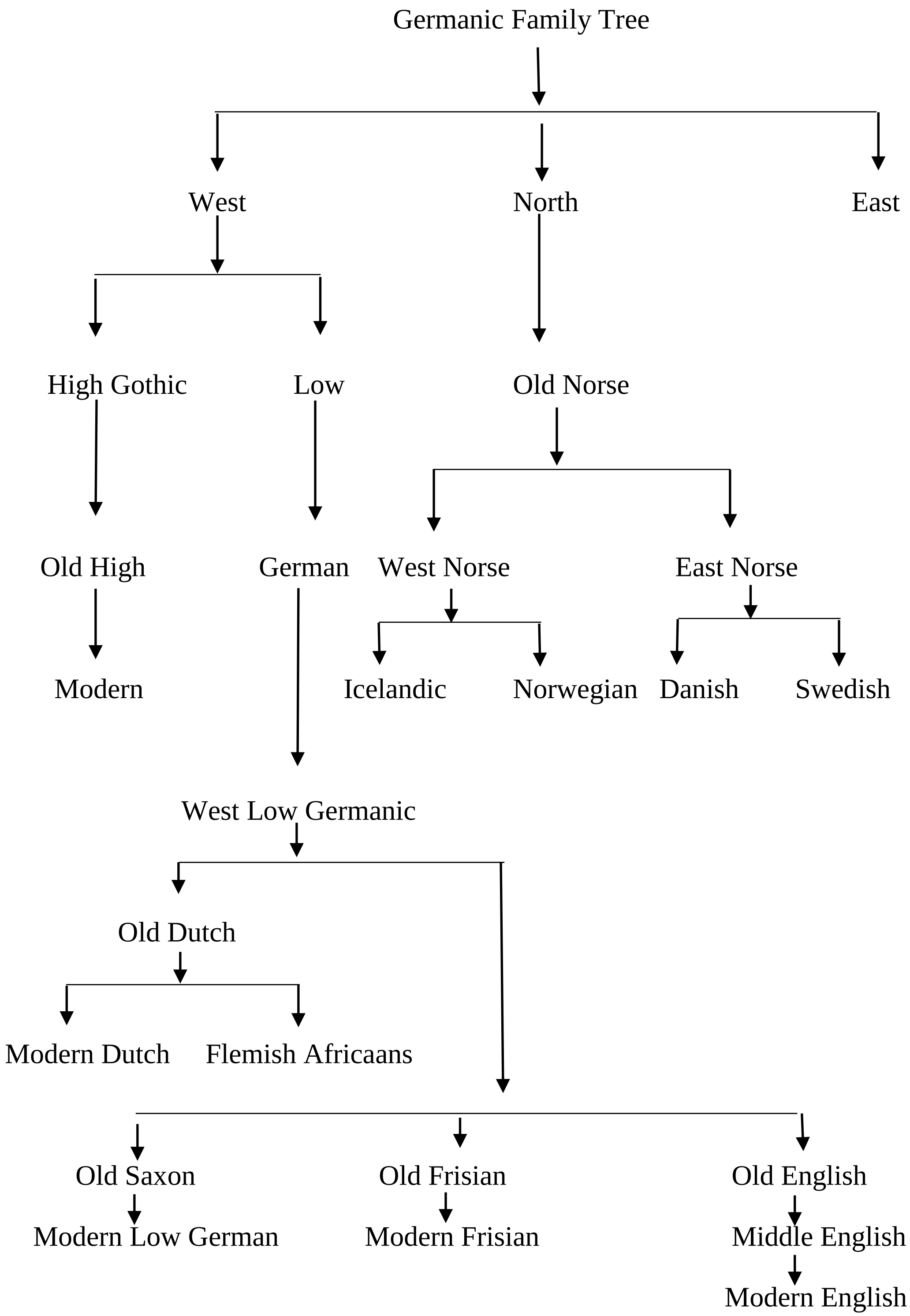


Figure 2. Germanic Family Tree (Drout, 2006: 60-61)

1.2. The Linguistic situation in Nigeria

Nigeria is a multilingual society. Regarded as the country with the most population in Africa, it is also one of the most linguistically diverse countries in the world. In the words of Araromi (2018), she is a multilingual and multicultural state. Most people in Nigeria are bilingual, having acquired a native language and English or any other language. Adegbite (2010) puts the total number to about 500 languages. However, Aiyeomoni (2012) posits that the number of indigenous languages spoken in Nigeria is still not clear. Akindele and Adegbite (2005) believe that the linguistic plurality of Nigeria was already in existence even before the implantation of English by the Europeans and has remained that way even after. However, Igbo, Hausa and Yoruba are officially recognized by the 2004 National Policy on Education as Nigeria's national and major languages because they are languages of wider communication spoken in 18 out of the 36 states that constitute Nigeria. Adekunle (1976) as cited by Haruna (2017) divides Nigerian languages into three classes: A, B and C. Class A includes the major indigenous languages: Igbo, Hausa and Yoruba. They are spoken outside their states of origin. Class B are languages that are officially recognized by government as national languages but not as widely spoken as those in Class A. The languages in this group are used at both federal and national levels. However, their popularity outside their states of origin is little when compared to the languages in the first class. They are Kanuri, Fulani, Edo, Efik, Tiv, and Ijo, amongst others. Class C are minority languages that do not have official government recognition. Examples include Ososo, Ekpari, Izon, and Bole, amongst others.

Other classifications of Nigerian languages abound in the literature. See Bran (1986), Oreka (2010) and Uman and Usman (2017). The next section of this study will briefly explore the implantation and status of English in Nigeria.

1.2.1. Implantation of English in Nigeria

Before the advent of English in Nigeria, the geographical area now known as Nigeria had its first contact with Portuguese traders in the 15th century in places like Warri, Brass and Calabar. Baugh and Cable (1978); Barber (1999) and Adenyaju (2004) aver that the Portuguese sea traders had sailed to the coast of West Africa for trade purposes. Akperokah (2018) asserts that the trade relationship with Nigeria was so healthy that the Portuguese merchants opened a seaport in Gwator, in the then ancient Benin Kingdom. Due to language barrier, communication between the indigenous people and the Portuguese was difficult, resulting in the need for them to learn a variant of Portuguese called Portuguese pidgin (Christopherson, 1953). Other European countries challenged the Portuguese monopoly of West Africans. Some of those countries include Britain, France, and Spain. The result of this was the contact between Britain and Nigeria, giving rise to the implantation of English in Nigeria. This implantation is viewed from three dimensions, namely: the pre-colonial, colonial and the period after the amalgamation.

From 1553, English citizens began to make visits to the shores of Nigeria. Historians believe that the Ports of Benin and Old Calabar benefitted from these visits. These visits and contact gave rise to the adoption of the English Pidgin as a means of communication to replace the Portuguese Pidgin. The trade contact between the Europeans and West Africans was mostly on gold, ivory, pepper and other raw materials. However, the trading system shifted from raw materials to the trans-Atlantic contraband trading of human beings: slave trade from 1650 - 1800 (Zueske, 2012). For ease of this infamous trade, some Nigerians had started learning the English language and had been trained as interpreters to the European slavers. Slave trade was abolished in the early 18th century and the former slaves who came back to Nigeria could communicate effectively in English as a result of their many years in England, USA and the Caribbean. Some of them were employed as clerks in government offices. This resulted in English becoming a borrowed linguistic medium coveted by the people who borrowed it to suit their purpose. After slave trade was abolished in Lagos, the Buxton, a British Christian society, held that the only panacea to the evils of slave trade was through a purification process by a group of people known as Christian Puritans. This led to the coming of European missionaries in Nigeria, especially British missionaries, a development that also contributed to the implantation of English in Nigeria.

The period from 1814 –1914 saw the influx of missionaries into Nigeria in large numbers. The coming of Rev. Thomas Freeman to Badagry in 1842, Rev. Hope Waddel of the Church of Scotland to Calabar in 1846 and Rev. Samuel Edgerly and others to Duke Town, Calabar in 1854 began the phase of formal acquisition of English in Nigeria. The missionaries in their bid to communicate effectively with the people, taught them English Language and how to read the Bible which was written in English. They also established schools where children were taught the basics of English. The Church Missionary Society (CMS) founded two schools in Badagry and a station in Abeokuta in 1846. The Methodist Church founded Methodist Boys High School, Lagos in 1876, Methodist Girls High School Lagos in 1879, and Gregory College, Obalende, Lagos in 1928. Similarly, Hope Waddel Institute was established in Calabar in 1895 and in the same manner, the first Christian mission was opened in Zaria in 1902. Through the establishment of these institutions, the popularity of English as a means of communication grew in leaps and bounds.

Remarkably, Britain's interest grew from just commercial adventure and missionary activities to the conquest ideology. Hence, in 1861, full blown colonialism was flagged off in Nigeria. With colonialism came a more organised education system that emphasized the teaching and learning of English. Government education grants to schools at that time was based on effective teaching and learning of English and people who showed strong proficiency at the use of English enjoyed preferences in government jobs and appointments. English was instituted as a sine qua non to a standard socioeconomic status.

Prior to the amalgamation of the Southern and Northern protectorates, Akperokah (2018) reports that education was in an abysmal state in Nigeria. Books were published in vernacular or indigenous languages. But the amalgamation marked the beginning of colonial interest standard education in Nigeria. For example, Adeniran (1978) reports that the use of indigenous languages for education purposes was restricted to just the primary and lower secondary schools. English was to be used for sciences, mathematics and official usage. English was flagged off as the language of education, employment, legislation, media and admission placement in schools. In summary, it would be appropriate to conclude that the factors such as trade, adventure, gospel propagation, colonialism, language attitude, education ordinance of 1896, certification system of 1842 and English as Nigeria's lingua-franca phenomenon, amongst others, contributed to the implantation and promotion of English in Nigeria. Today, English occupies an exalted status in Nigeria. This is highlighted briefly in the next section.

1.2.2. The status of English Language in Nigeria and its sociolinguistic consequences

The introduction, spread and promotion of English in Nigeria is not without consequences. First, it has contributed immensely to ensuring the continued complexity of multilingualism in Nigeria.

This is because most Nigerians, in order to be communicatively functional, need, in addition to their indigenous language, the English language. The National Language Policy holds that an individual should in addition to his/her native language or MT, speak one of the officially recognized Nigerian languages plus English. This policy is to be practised in the media, National Assembly and schools. This development has a simple implication: most Nigerian adults turn out to be either bilinguals or multilinguals or, put simply, polyglots with English occupying the centre stage as the compromise language. In section 1.2., it was established that some studies have put the number of indigenous languages in Nigeria at about 500. The addition of foreign languages like English, French, German, etc. makes the linguistic terrain of Nigeria to be a very complex one. But then, English is the only strong unifying language in Nigeria.

According to Adetugbo (1978:89), "English language has established itself firmly in Nigeria as probably the country's most important language." It enjoys a very high prestige and this may be the explanation for the positive disposition that Nigerians, including Igbo speakers, have towards the language. Some scholars even argue that the prestige accorded the language has resulted in the language being the L1 of some Nigerians, especially children of professional or middle class parents. Udofot (2007) affirms that in such homes where children acquire English first and the MT later, naturally, English gains dominance over any other language.

It can then be deduced from the above that English co-exists with other Nigerian languages. However, this coexistence is asymmetrical. English is exalted in status and function more than the other indigenous languages. It had earlier been posited that it is the compromise language that is assumed to be the only mutual means of communication among Nigerians from the different linguistic areas of the Nigerian State. Ekpe (2010:190) affirms this position by labelling it an "access language." This position that English occupies puts a lot of relevance on the language and hence a lot of functions.

First, it is the Nigerian language of education. This was made so by the Education Ordinance of 1896 which made English the operational language. Failure in English meant failure in the other subjects. Earlier education ordinances like the 1882 ordinance had established English as the only medium of instruction. This ordinance was heavily criticized resulting in the 1887 ordinance that accommodated the use of indigenous languages or vernacular in schools. English becomes a medium of instruction in the third year of primary school for every child in Nigeria.

After independence in 1960, legislations in Nigeria also favoured English. The National Policy on Education (1977) stipulates that the MT should be used as a medium of instruction in the first two years of primary school and the attainment of basic literacy in the MT is officially encouraged (Jowitt, 1991). For this reason, the National Language Centre in Lagos in collaboration with the Nigerian Educational Research and Development Centre has been charged with the responsibility of developing orthographies for as many Nigerian languages as possible. But after the first two years as directed by the policy, educational instruction is in English. All examinations, except the ones in Nigerian languages, are conducted in English. It is used to evaluate students in the First School Leaving Certificate Examinations, the Senior Secondary School Certificate Examinations, University Matriculation Examinations, etc.

English is also the language of the media. Jowitt (1991) posits that one important sign of the prominence of a language is its use in news broadcasting. English is used in both electronic and print media. The print media started in Lagos. As far back as the 19th century, the print media were already in circulation in Lagos. These publications were in English. *The Iwe Irohin* which loosely translates "newspaper" was also in circulation in some parts of Abeokuta though it was published in Yoruba. In contemporary times, dailies like *The Guardian, Vanguard, Times, Thisday, The Punch,* etc, and magazines like *This Week, NewsWatch,* etc. are equally in English. English dominates the mass media in Nigeria though some state-owned stations are making efforts to promote the casting of news in their local languages.

Furthermore, English is the language of science and technology. Much of the terminology in science are in English. This would include chemicals, formulae, etc. Even in information technology, most terms are in English as there are no words in any Nigerian language for "recharge cards, sodium chloride, compact disc, telephone, computer, laptop" etc., (Oyetade and Ekpe, 2010:34). Other functions of English in Nigeria include but are not limited to the following: the language of law and legal drafting, social interaction, government, public service, etc.

The inability of any Nigerian language, Igbo inclusive, to serve the purpose or functions that English serves makes it compelling that an average Nigerian acquire English either by learning or social interaction. Hence, contrastive studies such as this go a long way to unravel some of the learning difficulties that most Nigerians face as users of English as a second language (henceforth ESL) as well as make them know the linguistic options available to them judging from the differences and similarities between English and Nigerian languages. This work is one of such studies.

1.2.3. Bilingualism

The linguistic situation in Nigeria is pluralistic in nature but as established in section 1.2. above, the many indigenous languages exist side by side with English as the language of compromise, hence the idea of bilingualism in the Nigerian linguistic terrain. Most attempts that have been made to define bilingualism have been careful to strike a balance between bilingualism at individual and community levels because a bilingual individual could be a member of a monolingual society. Baker (2001) refers to the group level as *societal bilingualism* and personal possession of bilingualism as *individual bilingualism.* Blanc (2000) thinks societal bilingualism is a situation where a linguistic community uses two languages for interaction while Brice and Brice (2009) believes that an individual bilingual is someone who has the ability to listen, read and /or write in more than one language with varying degrees of proficiency. This is the linguistic reality for most Nigerians as most people have to alternate between English and other indigenous languages, such as English and Igbo. The linguistic plurality of Nigeria is further compounded by the existence of some exoglossic languages such as French and Arabic. Of all these, English, according to Banjo (1996) and Akindele and Adegbite (2005), occupies the exalted status of Nigeria's official language. It is the language of education, business, commerce and a whole lot. In this kind of situation and reality, cross-linguistic influences are expected to occur, resulting in some linguistic consequences of bilingualism. Therefore, works of this nature are needed to study the languages side by side in comparisons and contrasts, and hence proffer solutions to the discovered problems that bilingual users of these languages may encounter. Recommendations will also be made on how to improve the compatibility and usefulness of the plethora of languages in Nigeria.

1.3. The Igbo Language

Igbo is one of the indigenous languages in Nigeria. Nweya (2018) reports that Igbo is a language spoken by a culturally-related group of people found in the South-East zone of Nigeria. The zone is currently made-up of five states: Abia, Anambra, Ebonyi, Enugu, and Imo. Udoh (2004) adds that the language is also spoken in parts of Delta, Cross-River, Rivers, Benue and Akwa Ibom states.

According to Blench (2012), Igbo is a West Benue-Congo Igboid language. For Nwakwegu (2015), Igbo is a Kwa language of the new West Benue-Congo Igboid family, spoken by well over 20 million people. Emenanjo, Ndimele, Ohiri-Aniche, Ogbonna, Onwuma, Aimenwauu, Ujah, Eme and Okuma (2011) posit that Igbo is spoken as a first or second language by at least 35 million people. The current and exact population of the speakers of Igbo in Nigeria is not known since there has not been a population census since 2006[1] in which the population was put at 12, 206, 431 by the National Population Commission as a provisional figure. Igbo has some other dialectal divergences spoken across the states earlier mentioned. These dialects, we have to add, are mutually intelligible with the standard Igbo at some varying levels. Nwaozuzu (2008) has classified the Igbo speech into eight groups of geologically close varieties. These varieties show similar dialectal factors.

(WNGD)1. West Niger Groups of Dialects

(ENGD) 2. East Niger Groups of Dialects

(ECGD) 3. East- Central Groups of Dialects

(CRGD) 4. Cross River Groups of Dialects

(SEGD) 5. South-Eastern Groups of Dialects

(NEGD) 6. North-Eastern Groups of Dialects

(SWGD) 7. South-Western Groups of Dialects

(NGD) 8. Northern Groups of Dialects (Nwaozuzu 2008: 10)

Igbo is one of the most populous ethno-linguistic groups in Nigeria. The Igbo language is one of the three major indigenous languages in Nigeria. Among the dialectal divergences that exist across the Igbo speaking areas of Nigeria, scholars have worked frantically to come up with a

[1] Source: population.gov.ng

variety referred to today as standard Igbo or better known as *Igbo Izugbe* usually used in official contexts, Nwaozuzu (2008). It is also referred to as Central Igbo by scholars like Emenanjo (1978). This standard variety aligns with Nwaozuzu's (2008) classification of South-Eastern Group of dialects spoken in the South East of Nigeria. General grammar books in Igbo are written using this variety. Some of the grammar books include Emenanjo (1978. 1991, 2015), Uwalaka (1996), Ikekonwu, Ezikeojiaku, Ubani and Ugoji (1999), Uba-Mgbemena (2006), and Mbah and Mbah (2010). The data deployed for analysis in this study were drawn from this standard variety. The choice for this standard variety is because of popularity and acceptance by the Igbo-speaking populace and ease of communication. It is the variety that is spoken and understood amongst the Igbo irrespective of dialectal differences.

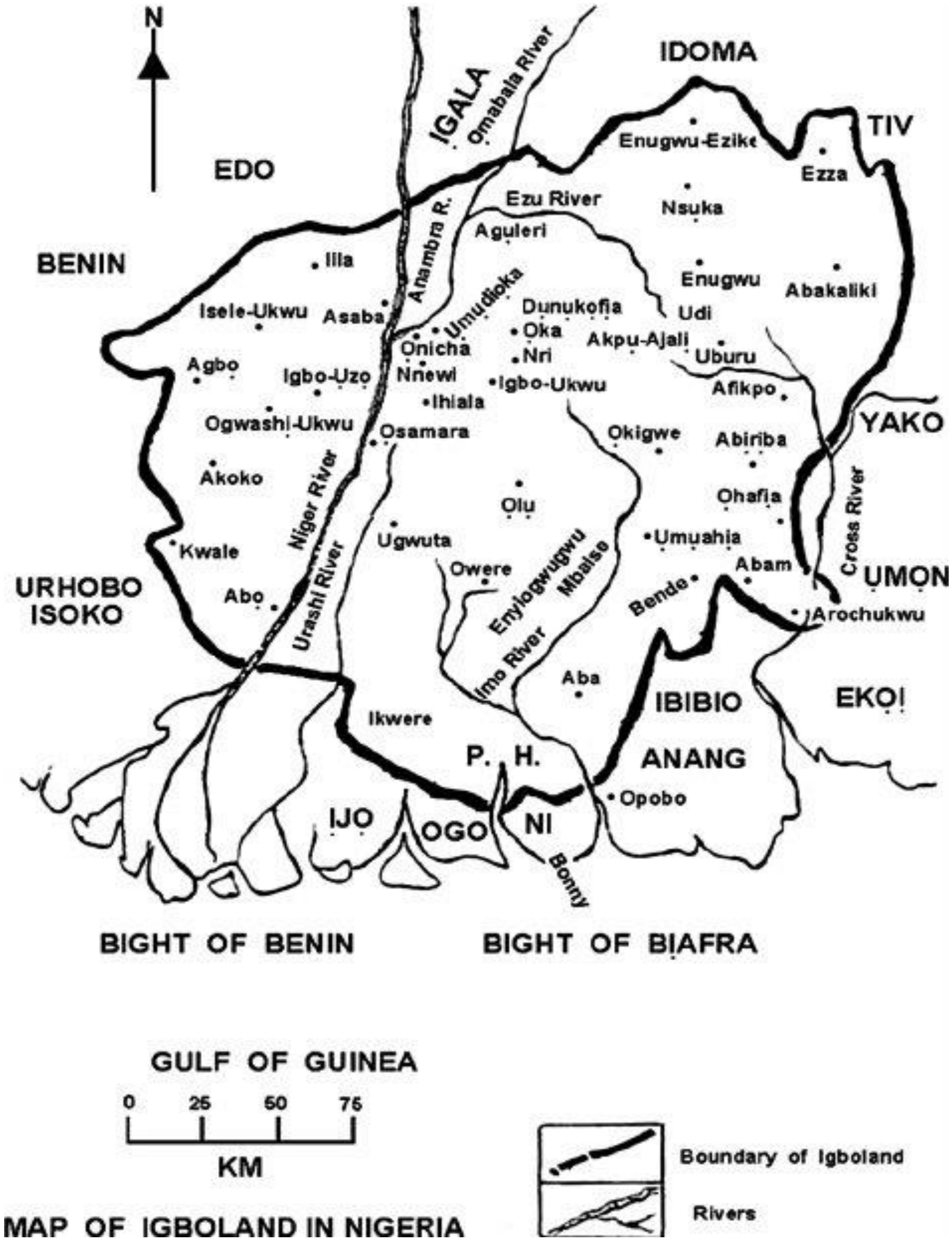


Figure 3: A map of Igboland in Nigeria showing Igbo speaking areas in the five South Eastern States of Abia, Anambra, Ebonyi, Enugu, and Imo States. (From http://igbology.igbonet.net)

1.4. Contrastive Analysis

Contrastive analysis (henceforth CA) aims to compare and contrast the features of two languages. Contrastive linguists or contrastivists like Di Pieto (1971) and James (1980) report that modern contrastive linguistics began with Lado's *Linguistics across Cultures* (1957). Ojo (1996) and Omolaiye (2013) report that Weinreinch's work of 1953 on the language integration of immigration of people who had migrated to the United States of America marked the foundation of CA.

Crystal (1992:20) puts it as "the influence of linguistic features of one language upon another." This interference can be in the form of negative or positive transfers. James (1980) reports that transfer is the psychological cornerstone of contrastive analysis. Positive transfer facilitates learning because forms of the L1 work correctly with those of L2. Crystal (1992) asserts that negative transfer takes place when the use of a native form produces an error in a foreign language. According to Lee (1968), the prime cause of difficulty and error on foreign language learning is interference coming from a learner's mother tongue (henceforth MT).

There are abundant definitions of contrastive analysis according to different scholars. James (1980:3) sees contrastive analysis as a "linguistic enterprise aimed at producing inverted (i.e. contrastive, not comparative) two-valued typologies." Contrastive analysts, as posited by Scholars like James (1980) and Sampson (1975), who came up with the concept of *particularist and generalist* approaches to language study, have been of the opinion that while languages have their peculiarities, they could still be studied side by side each other to identify what they have in common. This proves that CA is operational on the assumption that different languages can be compared and this comparison is more interested in areas of divergence and not in areas of convergence. *Routledge Encyclopedia of Language Teaching* (1990: 141) posits that CA can be classified into two: *Theoretical and Applied.* Theoretical CA looks at the extent to which there has to be an accurate and extensive account of observable areas of sameness or difference between or among the languages contrasted while *Applied CA,* on the other hand, is concerned with a reliable prediction of the learner's difficulties.

CA has close relationship with *error analysis* and *translation studies* .The concepts operate on the core tenets of *Interlingual studies.* They operate on the assumption that learning a second language or *text conversion/replacement* (translation studies or theory) is characterized by errors and issues, one of which is the problem of interference. Weinreich (1953: 88) observes that:

> It is the conclusion of common experience, if not yet
> a finding of psychologist research, that the language
> which has been learned , or the Mother Tongue is in
> a privileged position to resist interferences.

Hence, due to these issues, there is a conviction by contrastivists that linguistic differences as revealed by contrastive analysis could be used to predict learning difficulty and proffer solutions that will enable the teaching of a second language in the most effective way possible. Lado (1957: 267) asserts that where the language patterns are similar in the two languages compared, learners of the target language (TL) would find language relatively easy, because the "inputs" they are now exposed to are not new to them. On the other hand, where the language patterns of the TL and the MT differ, the learning of the TL would be relatively difficult. Contrastive analysis theory also has certain guiding significance to today's teaching of English in our schools. It can help foreign language teachers to understand and predict the kind of errors learners of any second language might commit so as to prevent such from happening. Through contrastive analysis studies such as this present study, teaching methodology is enhanced and perceived difficulties are eliminated.

1.4.1. Contrastive analysis hypothesis

Contrastive analysis hypothesis (CAH henceforth) is founded on the assumption that foreign language learners are negatively influenced by the features of their L1 and hence transfer such features to the L2. So, CAH holds that second language learners tend to encounter some levels of difficulties. Lado (1957:2) asserts, "an individual tends to transfer the forms and meaning of their native language and culture to the foreign language and culture." So, it could be argued that CAH has its core foundation in transfer theory. Transfers are inevitable whenever there is a contact of two or more languages. Coder (1974:158) defines transfer as "carrying over the habits of one's mother tongue into the target language. For Fries (1945) and Lado (1957), it is the imposition of L1 information on the sentences or utterances of the second language. Odlin (1989:27) posits that "transfer is the influence resulting from similarities and differences between the target language or any other language that has been previously (or perhaps imperfectly) acquired."

CAH has been viewed by scholars from the purview of strong, weak and moderate versions. On his submission for the strong version, Lee (1968) amongst other assumptions emphasized that the prime cause of difficulty or systematic deviations in L2 learning is MT interference. Similarly, these difficulties are chiefly as a result of the differences between the two languages.

The weak version holds that a contrastive analysis of two languages may help to shed light on the difficulties encountered by L2 learners and hence, the linguist has to deploy the best knowledge available to him to account for these difficulties. Oller and Ziahosseiny (1970) proposed the moderate version. They posit that errors in spelling or other deviations are products of interferences of similar patterns caused by learners' tendencies to falsely generalize.

Having considered these versions, this present study adopts the strong version as it provides a tool for two languages to be compared and contrasted and predict errors and/or other areas difficulties that may be occasioned by the differences in the languages.

1.5. Statement of the problem

The topic of ellipsis represents one of the great puzzles in the theory of grammar and has been engaged by linguists across languages of the world. Majority of the existing studies on the elliptical phenomenon have made attempts to investigate the grammatical licensing of the existing kinds of ellipsis: gapping, sluicing, pseudo gapping, fragments, VP ellipsis, NP ellipsis, and stripping amongst others in the English language. Some of these studies include Merchant (2001), Gengel (2007), Kertz (2010) and (2018) and so on. Other studies did a contrastive analysis of the ellipsis phenomenon in English and other languages like the Ngwa dialect of Igbo (Ugorji 2019), Libyan Arabic, Algryani (2012), Hindi-Urdu (Manetta 2018) and isiZulu (Bevis 2018) just to mention a few. In the midst of these studies, no similar attempt has been made to contrast English and Igbo. Hence, there is yawning gap for an investigation into the similarities and differences in the conditions for licensing elliptical structures in English and Igbo languages using English as a constant variable.

And to fill this yawning gap, this present study intends to embark on a contrastive interrogation of English language and Igbo with a view to discovering the idiosyncratic variations in licensing of elliptical structures such as VP-ellipsis, fragment ellipsis and NP-ellipsis in both languages since I-languages vary in the elements that are considered redundant and hence targeted for PF deletion. This contrastive examination will, therefore shed light on how both languages will be properly characterized with respect to the lexical items, constituents or categorial elements that they allow for PF deletion. Also, in doing this, the study will have addressed the two major components of Universal grammar: *the core* and *the periphery.* The core, points to features that exist across all languages while the peripheral features are specific to languages. According to Lamidi (2008: 52) “such features are marked and are hardly replicated in other languages.”

In addition to filling the gap, the study will have brought to fore the internal linguistic systems of the languages on how lexical items are derived, checked, moved and licensed for deletion at PF with strict adherence to the permutations of each language. This will further shed light on what is available to the Igbo users of English and what is not and therefore contribute to more effective teaching and learning of English.

1.6. Aim and objectives

The general aim of this study is to investigate and interrogate the similarities and differences that exist in the elliptical structures of English and Igbo. Specifically, the study intends to:

i. identify elliptical structures in English and Igbo and their respective licensing conditions

ii. compare and contrast these licensing conditions in both languages

iii. examine the role of semantics in licensing English and Igbo elliptical structures

iv. identify the extent of learning difficulties that may be occasioned by the differences between the two languages to the Igbo users of English

1.7. Research Questions

Following from the objectives of the study stated above, the questions below are posed to guide this research:

i. In what ways are VP-ellipsis, fragment ellipsis, and NP-ellipsis licensed in Igbo as in English?

ii. What are the similarities and differences in these licensing conditions?

iii. What is the role of semantics in licensing English and Igbo elliptical structures?

iv. What levels of learning difficulties may be encountered by Igbo learners of English due to these likely differences and similarities?

1.8. Scope of the Study

This study is confined within the scope of contrastive syntax. It would focus on some selected specific ellipsis phenomena like fragments, NP-ellipsis and VP-ellipsis in the English and Igbo languages. These ellipsis types were selected because they share some similarities in their tendency to target the verbs and other elements for PF deletion in English. However, the researcher, guided by his introspection as a native speaker of Igbo, suspects that the verb element PF deletion may not be attested in Igbo due to the syntactic and semantic roles played by verbs in the language. To corroborate this, Nwakwegu (2015) argues that very many of the functions played by distinct lexical categories in English are expressed somewhat via the verb system in Igbo. Hence, this study limits its scope to these ellipsis types in order to engage them in a robust research investigation so as to make sound and well-informed conclusions on the similarities and differences of the ellipsis debate between the two languages.

1.9. Significance of the study

This study contributes to existing scholarship on contrastive syntax. It ultimately reveals the internalized linguistic system or I-language which determines the ways native speakers use their languages, what they permit or what they do not in their language. It hopes to identify the parameters for licensing the selected elliptical structures in English and Igbo.

Pedagogically, the conclusions drawn from contrasting both languages is relevant in providing the hierarchies of problems that learners of English who are native speakers of Igbo might face in using elliptical structures. Hence, by identifying interlinguistic differences between English and Igbo, this study hopes to contribute to the facilitation of teaching and learning of English by Igbo speakers. It is, therefore, expected that the findings of this study will be useful to both teachers of English as a second language to Igbo learners and curriculum planners in the South Eastern part of Nigeria.

1.10. Justification of the Study

This study is justified as it is expected to fill the yawning gap in scholarship and existing literature on contrastive analysis of elliptical structures in English and Igbo. The bulk of work carried out across linguistic spheres has either been just on English or on English and other languages of the world. None exists on English and Igbo elliptical structures to the best knowledge of the researcher. The studies on Igbo have concentrated on Igbo clause structure, ergative structure, binding and co-reference and others. Studies on English and Igbo elliptical structures remain lacking in the syntax of Igbo in contrast with English. There is a need to fill this gap judging that English and Igbo have a mutual relationship in the linguistic landscape of Nigeria. This study, therefore, hopes to fill that gap and intends to come up with contributions on the universality and variations between English and Igbo with respect to elliptical structures.

1.11. Summary

Comparing languages to track their similarities and differences has been the concern of CA since its inception in Lado's (1957) posthumously published book *Linguistics across Cultures.* Lado (1957) posits that a more effective and proper learning of an L_2 is ensured if such L_2 is subjected to a contrastive study with the learner's language. This study is a demonstration of this assumption.

To actualize this assumption, this chapter has provided background knowledge to facilitate readers' understanding of the work. It specifically identified the research problem and placed the limit within which it intends to solve this problem. The chapter also highlighted the objectives that this study intends to achieve and how this study will be useful to society.

The next chapter highlights the concept of ellipsis, provides a review of previous studies and describes the choice of theory.

CHAPTER TWO

LITERATURE REVIEW AND THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

2.0. Introduction

This chapter contains a review of relevant literature: conceptual and empirical. It is important to note that the study intends to look at elliptical structures from the perspective of generative syntax but considers it important to give a general overview of the ellipsis phenomenon by scholars outside generative syntax as seen in **section 2.1.2.1.** The chapter also presents an exploration into the theoretical underpinning chosen for this study.

2.1. Literature Review

2.1.2. Conceptual Review

2.1.2.1. Definition and general insight into the ellipsis phenomenon

Some scholars have made attempts to explain the ellipsis phenomenon in earlier studies. Lyons (1977: 589) thinks that ellipsis is "grammatically incomplete, but contextually appropriate and interpretable sentence fragments." This means that for Lyons, elided structures are missing syntactically but are understood from context. He goes further to assert that "a conversation consisting entirely of grammatically completed text-sentences would generally be unacceptable as a text, and it is part of the language competence of a speaker of the language to use and accept such incomplete structures in conversations". In essence, Lyons considers the ellipsis as a phenomenon that is naturally expected to happen in conversations. He gives the following examples:

1. As soon as I can.
2. When are you leaving? (Lyons, 1977: 589)

Lyons argues that (1) produced above with the appropriate stress pattern and intonation might occur in a text in reply to an utterance (intended and taken as a question). Number (1) for him can be seen as the elliptical, contextualized version of the utterance: "I am leaving as soon as I can ". Thus, ellipsis is one of the most obvious effects of contextualization in the case of sentence fragments. From the observation made above, one would be interested to interrogate Lyon's position as misleading as there is an understanding that ellipsis involves " leaving out a part of a structure because it is understood from an earlier established structure, but Lyon's position seems to depend too much on contextualized conversations.

Brown and Miller, (1985:151) posit that ellipsis are " structures that are to be greater or lesser degree either grammatically or semantically incomplete or both; grammatically incomplete insofar as constituents have been elided; semantically incomplete inasmuch as the sentence can only be understood with reference to their contexts". In both cases, these sentence fragments as they refer to the elided structures can only be fully understood by reference to some understood, fuller forms where the items have been elided or reduced to *proforms*. They added that the amount of grammatical and contextual interpretations necessary can be appreciated if we consider for example:

3. She wouldn't.
4. Mary wouldn't shut the door.
5. Mary wouldn't feed the cat. or
6. Jane wouldn't give up smoking.

(Brown and Miller, 1985:151)

We could understand that (3) above would only be understood as (4) in the specific context and may also be understood as (5) and (6) in other contexts. Therefore, we could argue that Brown and Miller's position is similar to Lyon's position where the ellipsis is understood in the light of other preceding structures in the context.

However, Lyons (1989) revised his position on the ellipsis phenomenon. He argues that ellipses are shorter forms of some longer versions of the same sentence, and that elliptical structures can be understood to refer to a grammatically equivalent but perhaps syntactically distinct forms as occurring in otherwise identical sentences. His argument is that ellipsis is a manner of speaking targeted at reducing the word quantity of an expression and still making or passing the same message. Therefore, there is a need to make a distinction between grammatical and contextual completeness that occur in structures with ellipsis and ones without ellipsis.

Quirk and Greenbaum (1973:263) also established their positions on the ellipsis phenomenon. For them, "the ellipsis is most commonly used to avoid repetition, and in this respect; it is like substitution. They provided the following examples:

7. She might sing, but I don't think she will (*sing*).[2]

8. She might sing, but I don't think she will do so.

(Quirk and Greenbaum, 1973:263)

They explain that in the example (7) above, the word "sing" has been elided but that the use of a pro-form expressed by the pro-verb “will do” in example (8) is also a form of ellipsis. This is because the intended sentence would be:

9. She might sing, but I don’t think she will sing.

Halliday and Hasan (1976:143) see the ellipsis as a cohesive device; and “the cohesive effect achieved by the selection of vocabulary.” It is “something understood”; or “sentences, clauses, etc whose structure is such as to presuppose a preceding item, which then serves as the source of the missing information.” The elliptical item leaves structural slots to be filled from elsewhere. They add that grammatical cohesion, on the other hand, refers to the structural content, and it is categorized into four main cohesive ties: reference, substitution, ellipsis, and conjunction. Ellipsis, according to them is a kind of substitution but in substitution, something like a place-marker is used for what is presupposed unlike in ellipsis where nothing is inserted in the “slot.” In ellipsis, a lexical item is substituted by *zero*. This implies the item is left unsaid to avoid unnecessary repetition or redundancy. The example (10) below is provided by them:

10. Joan brought some carnations and Catherin some sweet peas.

[2] The elided structures are enclosed in a pair of round brackets here.

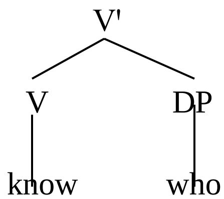
2.1.2.2. Ellipsis in generative syntax

In generative syntax, the ellipsis phenomenon has occupied the focal point of argument in studies with scholars arguing on different approaches to licensing the ellipsis site. To define ellipsis in the tradition of generative syntax, van Craenenbroeck and Merchant (2013:1) consider the ellipsis as "deletions" "involving a number of cases where otherwise expected material goes missing under some conditions." It is a constituent that undergoes deletions and where any material survives such deletions, such material is evacuated via movement at an earlier stage of derivations. According to Lasnik (2005) cited in Gengel (2007:19), the ellipsis targets "some offending materials" that would cause violations at the interfaces if spelled out using an approach known as "repair by deletion." For Algryani (2012:1), it is "the omission of elements that can be recovered from context." Lobeck (1995:20) defines ellipsis as the 'omission of a syntactic constituent under identity with an antecedent in the preceding discourse'. Hankamer and Sag (1976) argue that ellipsis can involve deep or surface anaphora. Deep anaphora receives their interpretation from a pragmatic antecedent whereas surface anaphora require an overt linguistic antecedent. For instance, the pragmatic antecedent can license the anaphoric proform. Some studies including Tancredi (1992), Chomsky and Lasnik (1993), Lasnik (1995a) and Merchant (2001) agree that there is a syntactic structure in the ellipsis site which is mapped straightforwardly onto LF and hence undergoes PF deletion. Algryani (2012) reports that the syntax of ellipsis has been explained in two distinct approaches: structural and non-structural approaches.

The structural approach operates on the assumption that the ellipsis site actually contains a structure. Gengel (2007) reports that this syntactic structure is moved for PF deletion because its content is filled at LF and its materials recovered from the antecedent. Popular among the structural approach school of thought are the null proforms theory, LF copy theory, and PF deletion theory. Some proponents include Fiengo and May (1994), William (1997), etc. This study bases its judgement of ellipsis licensing by using the PF deletion approach.

The non-structural approach has been robustly engaged in studies like (van Riemsdijk 1978; Culicover and Jackendoff 2005). This approach claims that there is no syntactic structure in the ellipsis site. They argue against positing a structure in ellipsis at any level of representation. This means that the structure is unpronounced. Proponents of non-structural approach are of the opinion that the *sluiced* (elided or deleted) WH phrase in (11), for example, is a bare WH fragments, generated as an XP (DP, PP, AP) and functioning as a complement to the main verb (Culicover and Jackendoff, 2005).

11. Someone called you, but I don't know who ~~called you~~.



However, recent studies have proposed that the ellipsis in sluicing contains syntactic structure. Lasnik (2001), (2007), Merchant (2001), Albrecht (2010), van Craenenbroeck (2010a and 2010b) argue that the WH phrase in (11) is not a mere DP but part of a clausal constituent. There is evidence for this based on number agreement, morphological case marking, preposition stranding, and distributional properties.

2.1.2.3. Types of ellipsis in generative syntax selected for the study

The kinds of ellipsis (VP-ellipsis, fragment ellipsis and NP-ellipsis) selected for this study are briefly highlighted below. Chapter 4 will provide more details.

VP-ellipsis

Verb phrase ellipsis involves the deletion of an entire verb phrase. In this kind of ellipsis, the VP (i.e. the verb and everything following it, except the word “*too*”) is elided. Gengel (2007) reports that another important property of VP-ellipsis in English is that the ellipsis site is always preceded by an auxiliary or modal verb. Johnson, (2008a: 6) suggests that VP-ellipsis is a type of, “radical,” deaccenting where elided material has been ‘deaccented’ right into silence. This simply holds that while the elided portion of a sentence is not pronounced, nothing has changed the syntactic structure of the sentence. Examples:

12. Mary met Bill at Berkeley and *Sue did too.*

13. Charles thinks that Mary met Bill at Berkeley, but *Sarah knows that Sue didn't*

(Gengel 2007: 16)

The intended reading of the above examples would have been:

14. Mary met Bill at Berkeley and Sue did meet Bill at Berkeley too.
15. Charles thinks that Mary met Bill at Berkeley, but Sarah knows that she didn't meet Bill at Berkeley.

However, the VPs: "meet bill at Berkeley" have been elided in both syntactic derivations. These VPs occurred in the target clause (the TP that houses the ellipsis site) and as established above, were preceded by the auxiliaries, "did" and "didn't" which triggered their deletions since their message content is recoverable from context.

Fragments

Fragmentary utterances or responses are shortened expressions used as answers to questions. They consist of non-sentential XPs. They are non-clausal structures understood to be remnants of some ellipsis process. The full-sentential counterparts are said to have undergone PF deletion. The fragment is treated as an eventual remnant that is focused-moved to the left periphery of the derivation. Example:

16. Q: a. When did he say he would come?

    b. *in the morning*

    c. He said that he would come in the morning.

(Merchant, (2004: 665)

In example (16) above, the fragmentary utterance in (a) is a reduced form of the full sentence counterpart in (c) where its context is dependent and recoverable from.

NP-Ellipsis

This involves the deletion of an NP in the ellipsis site and sometimes inserting a QP or possessive element. Gengel (2007) reports that there is a rich attestation of NP Ellipsis in English, and comes in two variants, so to speak, with and without one-insertion. In this instance of ellipsis, the deletion site comprises the material following the quantifiers which is an NP as it is seen in example (17) or an NP introduced by numerals (18), possessives (19), or demonstratives (20).

17. John called out the children's names, and many/few/all/each/some [e] answered.

(Lobeck 1995: 45)

18. The students attended the play but two [e] went home disappointed.

(Kester 1996:195)

19. Although John's friends were late to the rally, [NP Mary's [e]] arrived on time.

(Gengel 2007: 16)

20. Although she might order these [e], Mary won't buy those books on art history.

(Kester 1996:195)

To explain with (17) above, the Logical Form of the derivation is provided in (21) below.

21. John called out the children's names and many/few/all/each/some child(ren) refused to answer.

The NP "child(ren)" has been elided. This elided NP was introduced by a quantifier, "many, few, all, each and some" as established above. The *[e]* in the ellipsis sites above following the quantifiers, numeral, possessive and demonstrative represent the elided NP.

This section of this study has briefly highlighted the selected ellipsis types. Chapter 4 of this work explores these concepts in a more detailed demonstration.

2.1.2.4. Syntax and Semantics debate on ellipsis licensing

Note that licensing condition is a mechanism that provides for the permission an element has to exist in any part of a derivation. Elements are not just haphazardly dropped anywhere. Heads license complements. For instance, inflection or verbs and prepositions are case licensors in

English. However, for this element to be permitted, it has to have its features **checked** by the licensor (Please see section **2.2.1.** for details on **Feature checking in the MP).** Scholars are divided on the licensing conditions of the ellipsis site. Algryani (2012) argues that the ellipsis phenomenon is an interdisciplinary topic that may involve the interface of syntax, semantics, phonology and /or pragmatics. Kertz (2010) also reviewed some theoretical assumptions on the ellipsis phenomenon. She asserts that within the theoretical literature, two approaches to the ellipsis phenomenon have existed side by side. The first approach is tailored towards a semantic relationship. This approach is comparable in many ways to the co-reference phenomenon observed for pronominal anaphors and their antecedents. It holds that ellipsis is licensed based on semantic identity between the elided structure and its antecedents.

In contrast, the second approach holds that ellipsis is licensed by a structural identity condition, usually applied at an abstract level of representation referred to as Logical Form (LF). Hence, the argument boils down to the assumption that syntactic identity is required to license an ellipsis. Sag (1976), a major proponent of this approach, argues that surface structure identity is too strict and semantic identity condition is too permissible. The LF formulation is just right in considering licensing an ellipsis (Kertz 2010). Example:

22. Peter is complaining about the noise, but John won't (complain about the noise)

23. *Paul denied the charge, but the charge wasn't (denied) by his friends.

(Sag , 1976)

Sag argues that the ellipsis in example (22) is acceptable while example (23) is not. Example (23) is not acceptable because of the voice mismatch between the antecedent and target clauses. Notice that the voice of the verb in the antecedent clause “Paul denied the charge” is active while that of the target clause, “but the charge wasn’t ~~denied~~ by his friends” is passive. Example (23) for Sag, proves that a semantic relationship between the antecedent clause and the target clause is not sufficient to license ellipsis; structural identity (encoded at the level of the LF) is also required. However, (22) is acceptable despite affix marking mismatch between the antecedent clause and the target clause (the ellipsis site). Notice that the tense of the verb “is complaining” is progressive in the sentence: “Peter is complaining” while it is not in the in the second sentence: John won't (complain about the noise). This shows that surface structure identity is not required.

Sag, however, adds that some instances of voice mismatch do not totally render the ellipsis site unacceptable as seen in the example below.

24. Botanist: That can all be explained.

    Mr. Speck: Please, do. (Explain)

Other scholars have collected more examples of situations when mismatches are acceptable. The data they collected were subjected to corpora and spontaneous conversation. As in the examples below.

25. A lot of these materials can be presented in a fairly informal and accessible fashion and *I often do*.

(Dairymple et al., 1991.)

26. This information could have been released by Gorbachev, but *he chose not to*.

(Hardt, 1993)

27. Four fireworks manufacturers asked that the decision be reversed, and *on Monday, the ICC did.*

(Dairymple et al., 1991)

28. This problem was not to have been looked into, but *obviously, nobody did.*

(Kehler, 2000)

(All cited in Kertz, 2010: 5)

In all the examples above, there is a mismatch between the antecedent clause and the target clause (the domicile of the ellipsis site), but the ellipsis is acceptable. Some of these scholars provide detailed support for their respective positions.

Dairymple (2012) in furtherance of his arguments against the syntactic proposal, posits that most of the arguments concern the manner of binding or antecedent relations of ellipsis that contain pronouns and traces. He believes that the problem of mismatch stems from there.

Kennedy (2003) assembles a large quantity of data on the mismatch debate (acceptable mismatches and unacceptable ones). He opines that, following the syntactic approach, unacceptable mismatches were as a result of binding and extraction violations. In addition, he asserts that even though mismatches are ungrammatical and unacceptable, they are attested and as such constitute "a fact about English." Over the last decade, attempts have been made at theoretically underpinning the syntax and semantics debate in order to provide explanations for cases of acceptable and unacceptable mismatch.

For example, Kehler (2000; 2002) opted for a semantic model of ellipsis which holds that there has to be constraints between the antecedent clause and target clause to ensure discourse coherence. He argues that "inferencing" that is necessary for establishment of coherence is sensitive to syntactic identity or structure and for this reason, mismatches are unacceptable in such cases. In other words, acceptability for mismatched antecedents in ellipsis is conditioned on coherence relations which obtain between the antecedent and the target clauses. Unacceptable mismatches are characterized by a feature he calls "RESEMBLANCE" coherence relations. This feature highlights sameness or contrasts that are seen in events and their participants and they are also bound by semantic parallelism. On the other hand, acceptable mismatches occur not with the earlier "Resemblance coherence" relations but with other types of relations like CAUSE-EFFECT relations (bound by causality). The examples below illustrate this more.

29. This problem was to have been looked into by John, but *obviously nobody did.*

(violated expectation)

CAUSE-EFFECT

30. #[3] This problem was looked into by John and *Bob did too.*

(parallel)

[3] Kehler uses this symbol to show reduced acceptability.

RESEMBLANCE

(Kehler 2000 no. 24&34)

In example (29), there is a coherence relation obtaining between the antecedent and the target. This is a "violated expectation" relation, an instance of CAUSE – EFFECT. Here, the natural inference which follows from the assorted content of the antecedent is that the problem was actually looked into. The antecedent clause is a mismatch of the target clause: "but obviously, nobody did" because the antecedent is passive while the target is active. The asserted content is also inconsistent with the inference of the antecedent forming what Kehler calls "violated expectation." Hence, it is an acceptable mismatch by his standards. Another violated expectation is that there is a mismatch between the passivized subject of the antecedent *John* and that of the target *nobody.* The expectation is that *John* either did or did not do. Example (30) also demonstrates a voice mismatch but shows reduced acceptability because of the sameness between events and their participants, resulting in semantic parallelism or parallel relation. What he seems to be saying is that the participants "John" and "Bob" and the event: "was looked" are semantically parallel since both participants performed the same event of "looking into the problem." Hence, the target clause "and *Bob did too"* which contains the ellipsis is clumsy and unacceptable.

Arregui et al., (2006), present a model "Recycling Model Hypothesis" which argues that gradient acceptability pattern for mismatched ellipsis can be predicted based on the cost necessary to repair an ill-formed antecedent. Here, well-formed antecedent are copied at the ellipsis site and ill-formed antecedents are repaired prior to being copied. This repair is syntactic, putting licensing operations like syntactic displacements and derivational morphological processes to use. They opine that syntactic repairs requiring multiple operations are more costly than ones with fewer operations. The first repair mechanism they suggest is "Antecedent Identification" which prefers antecedents that occur as matrix (as opposed to embedded) verb phrase. Prepositional triggers like particles "too" are also used in this antecedent identification to show or imply to the hearer that a matched antecedent is either available or was intended by the speaker. Example,

31. The student was praised by the old schoolmaster and *the advisor did too*

32. # The student was praised by the old schoolmaster and *the advisor did*.

(Arregui et al., 2006 cited in Kertz, 2010:22)

In practice, example (31) will be easier to process, or, put differently, more acceptable than (32) because it contains the presupposition particle "too" which is lacking in example (32).

Arregui et al., (2006) also introduced what they refer to as "Systematic Paraphrase Hypothesis" which is a recycling approach that involves memory for surface syntactic form. The prediction is that ellipsis which features a passive antecedent followed by an active target will be easier to process than the other way around. For them, this is a memory-based effect whereby speakers and hearers find it easier to incorrectly remember a marked structure as its unmarked alternative than the other way around. Markedness here is judged based on derivation. The derived alternate (active) is more marked than its base (passive) less marked one. Example:

33. The student was praised by the old schoolmaster and *the advisor did (too)*

34. # The advisor praised the student, and *the old schoolmaster was (too)*

Within the purview of Arregui et al.'s Systematic Paraphrase Hypothesis. (33) is more acceptable than (34) because in (33), the passive (unmarked) or (base) comes first since the meaning of the active (marked) is derived or dependent on it. This is to avoid, according to them, misremembering.

Drawing insight from the above studies, this present study attempts to explore and explicate the role of semantics in the syntax of the selected ellipsis types in English and Igbo. This is justified as the studies above have demonstrated that there has to be a certain level of semantic relationship between the antecedent clause and the target clause (ellipsis site) to determine the grammaticality and acceptance of an ellipsis.

2.1.3. Empirical Studies on the ellipsis phenomenon

This section presents a review of previous studies on the ellipsis phenomenon across different languages. The chosen studies were conducted on languages that have SVO word-order similarities with English and Igbo.

Bevis (2018) conducted a comparative research of the ellipsis phenomenon between English and IsiZulu. The study reveals that isiZulu does seem to have a type of VP ellipsis which is just like English, unlike Bantu, the family language of the isiZulu where the English kind of VP-ellipsis is not attested but verb stranding VP-ellipsis is attested. It refers to this as an “unexpected finding.” It observes that VP ellipsis has an auxiliary that precedes the ellipsis site. This auxiliary is an important element in the licensing of VP-ellipsis. Using Merchant’s (2010) theory of VP-ellipsis, the study holds that there is a special device called [E], which is responsible for licensing an ellipsis site. Also, “identity” and “recoverability” show a connection between an ellipsis site and its antecedent which allows for the elided material to be interpreted. It points out that the literature on identity and recoverability are divided as some scholars argue for syntactic identity while others argue for semantics. The other observation from the study concerns the nature of the ellipsis site itself. It argues that while it may look like there are no syntactic materials in the ellipsis site, there is evidence which suggests that the ellipsis contains a syntactic structure that goes unpronounced.

In addition, the study recognizes the two accounts of gapping: the account that holds that gapping is a product of movement (Johnson 2008b) and the theory that sees gapping as a type of phonological deletion (Hartmann 2000). This current study is also interrogating the syntax of fragments, NP ellipsis and VP-ellipsis. However, while, Bevis (2018) contrasted English and isiZulu, this present study is an exploration into the ellipsis phenomenon in English and Igbo. It aims to improve the teaching and learning of English to Igbo speakers of English.

Similarly, Ugorji (2019) studied elliptical structures in Ngwa-Igbo, a dialect of Igbo spoken in the geo-political area known as Ngwa land. The study revealed that ellipsis is a natural phenomenon in Ngwa-Igbo and that it mostly occurs in coordinate structures and in question and answer pairs. It notes that ellipsis could lead to generic reading of some structures, but the context of speech helps to resolve instances of ambiguity. Findings reveal that gapping, VP-Ellipsis, pseudogapping, stripping are licensed in Ngwa-Igbo. While Ugorji (2019) examined some elliptical structures in a dialect of Igbo (the Ngwaa Dialect), this present study is a contrastive investigation between Standard Igbo and English with a view to improving the learning of English to Igbo learners of English.

In another study, Algryani (2012) investigated the syntax of sluicing, VP-ellipsis, stripping and negative contrast in Libyan Arabic also known as Modern Standard Arabic (MSA). The language displays variations between SVO and VSO, VOS and OVS word orders. It notes that SVO is predominant and is argued to be the basic word order. The study shows that there is compelling evidence that several ellipsis sites contain syntactic structures which can be treated as PF deletion phenomenon. The study discovers that sluicing occurs both in Standard Arabic and in the local varieties of Arabic. Arabic sluicing resembles English sluicing in the sense that it leaves a wh- remnant behind. Furthermore, as in other languages, Arabic sluicing is only licensed by interrogative complementizer. The study, additionally, explored the phenomenon of ***contrast sluices.*** It defined ***contrast sluices*** according to (Merchant 2001: 150) as "those structures in which the descriptive content in the sluiced wh-phrase clashes with that of its correlate." It finds that contrast sluices in Arabic are acceptable.

Further, the study finds that VP ellipsis also exists in Libyan Arabic but only in specific contexts. It observes that unlike in other varieties of Arabic such as Moroccan Arabic, the basic auxiliary 'be' forms cannot license VP ellipsis in Libyan Arabic. Moreover, the language does not have equivalents to the English pro-forms of **do** or the perfective auxiliary ***have*** that can license VP ellipsis in English. The typical cases of verb phrase ellipsis in Libyan Arabic are those licensed by the modal. Finally, the study finds that modal ellipsis, a verb phrase related ellipsis, deletes the complement of the modal verbs while verb stranding deletes the complement of the main verb and all vP- related materials because the lexical verb is believed to have raised to T. With regard to stripping and negative contrast, the study proposes that both constructions involve TP ellipsis where the remnant in such constructions is moved to the left periphery followed by TP deletion. While Algryani (2012) was on English and Libyan Arabic, this present study is on English and Igbo. Algryani's study may have improved the teaching and learning of English in the areas where Libyan Arabic is spoken. This present study is expected to do same in the Igbo speaking areas of Nigeria where English is the language of education.

Ntelitheos (2004), using evidence from Greek, an SVO language, provides a unified account of nominal ellipsis and discontinuous DPs. He argues that standard analyses have always treated the nominal ellipsis and discontinuous DPs as separate phenomena but that the two processes are common because they share the same licensing mechanisms, syntactic realization of information structure, same type of modifiers, and same morphological properties of modifiers. The study further argues that nominal ellipsis is a complex process that involves syntactic movement of DP-internal constituent NP to a position associated with properties of the discourse function of topic. This movement precedes phonological deletion of the moved NP, and hence produces the elliptical structure in nominal domain. Simply put, the study shows that NP-deletion is preceded by NP topicalization.

The study explains when NPs are elided, they must refer to a subset of the superset denoted by the antecedent occurrence of NPs. They cannot refer to NPs that are unspecified in the previous discourses. It however, finds some problems between nominal ellipsis and discontinuous DPs. This problem is that not all languages that allow for elliptical structures in the nominal domain also allow for discontinuity in the DP. For example in English, quantifiers and demonstratives can license nominal ellipsis but it is impossible in discontinuous DPs. The study however, submits that what is needed in a language to allow for a discontinuous DP is not clear, Greek inclusive. While this study is on nominal ellipsis in Greek, the present study is a contrastive study of fragments, VP and NP ellipsis between English and Igbo with the intention of improving English language.

Corver and van Koppen (2006) worked on noun ellipsis using the Dutch data. They argued that ellipsis in the nominal domain is possible if the remnant of the ellipsis is **focused**. They added that focus marking is often attested on the remnant of ellipsis by a focus marker, stress, or strong form of the remnant. Their study finds that the focus markers *en* and *e* in Dutch are related to the indefinite article and that constructions involving indefinite articles doubling and focus markers receive the same analysis. The *e-suffix* is associated with emphatic force and when the attributive AP is emphasized, the *e-suffix* appears on the adjective. They find that, however, apart from Standard Dutch, the dialect of Grave has no *e-suffix* on the attributive adjective.

Also, the study finds that noun ellipsis happens when the adjective is inflected. It is the inflection that licenses the gap. It adds that ellipsis of indefinite neuter nouns in not totally possible. It is only possible when the gap is embedded in a contrastively focused constituent. This current study will also look at the syntax of nominal ellipsis. However, while Corver and van Koppen (2006) examined the syntax of nominal ellipsis in Dutch, this present study is contrasting nominal ellipsis in English and Igbo.

2.2. Theoretical Framework

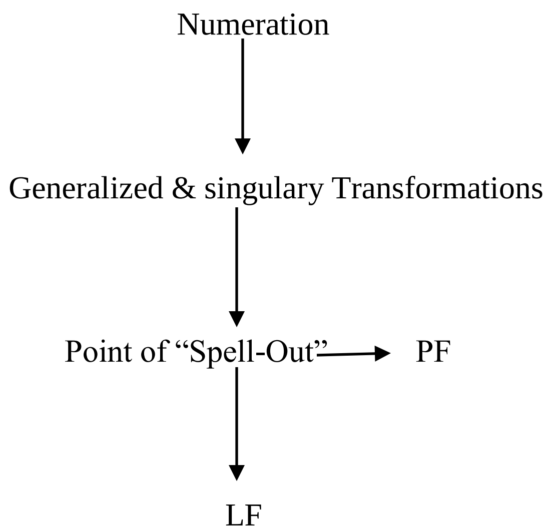
This study is anchored on the Minimalist Program (MP).

2.2.1. The Minimalist Program

The Minimalist Program (MP) is a model of linguistic description in Transformational Generative Grammar that is driven on the assumption that the computational system of human language has to be as perfect and as precise possible by cutting down on any unnecessary process. MP makes use of basic computational operations to achieve its economy driven goal. Chomsky (2015: 157) observes that MP "is a theory of language that takes a linguistic expression to be nothing other than a formal object that satisfies the interface conditions in the optimal way." Cook and Newson (2007) note that the core idea behind MP is that analysis should proceed on the minimal number of assumptions and make case of the minimal number of grammatical mechanisms. According to Crystal (2003), MP is a development in generative thinking, which emphasizes the aim of making statements about language as simple and as general as possible.

Chomsky (1993: 186, 2015: 154) explains that MP assumes that language consists of two components: *a lexicon and a computational system* with their idiosyncratic features. The lexicon provides the computational system with lexical items and the computational system uses these elements in derivation, generation, and structural descriptions (SDs). Derivations in Chomsky's syntax operates at two cognitive systems of Conceptual Intentional System and the Articulatory - Perceptual system which define two interface levels: Phonological Form (PF) and is at the Interface of Articulatory-Perceptual System and Logical Form (LF), at the interface to the Conceptual-intentional system. The PF and LF are the only linguistic levels considered relevant in the MP. It is this recognition that cardinally distinguishes MP and Government and Binding (GB) owing to the fact that the latter recognizes D-Structure, S-structure, PF and LF.

See the components as arranged in the human brain below.



(Lasnik, 2005:81)

The above provides that linguistic expressions are progressions of representations that begin from the ***Lexicon***, ***Numeration*** or ***Lexical Array*** to the **Logical Form**. Citko (2014) explains that the difference between **Numeration** and ***Lexical Array*** is that the former specifies the number of times a lexical item has been selected from the ***Lexicon.*** She, however, adds that both terms are equivalents. So, in practice, scholars have used them interchangeably. The PF and LF interfaces are the representations of the output. Chomsky (1995:229) explains that, "the two interface representations are different and one is not derived from the other." Also, the terms, PF and LF are used to refer to the interface with the ***Sensorimotor (SM)*** and ***C-I systems***, respectively. (See the schema on page 42). It is at the point of ***spell out*** that the computation splits, where LF is the abstract representation of meaning and PF is the abstract representation of sound.

There are some general operations involved in the derivation process in the MP. They are operations *select, merge, and move.* Clause derivation in MP witnesses ***selection*** of lexical items from the lexicon at the *Numeration* also known as the *computational systems* (Lasnik 2005:131, Lamidi 2008:63) and ***merges*** them in the structure to generate *derivations* or *Structural Descriptions*. To ***merge*** is to combine the lexical items earlier ***selected*** from the lexicon. Merge can operate as a singulary or a generalized transformation. The output of the merge operation is known as basic phrase structures because there is a combination of two or more syntactic objects. We can illustrate the operation merge below.

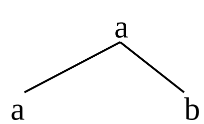
Merge Condition

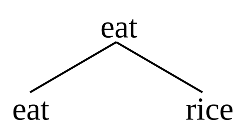
Merge **α** and **β** if **α** can value a feature **β** (Wurmbrand, 2012: 2)

Put differently,

a. Merge [**α, β**] ⟶ [**α, (α β)**]

b. Merge [eat, rice] ⟶ [eat (eat rice)]





Should any principle of grammar be violated in the course of this, the derivation is said to ***crash***. Spell-out takes place at a stated level of this derivation. Spell-out is simply an instruction to switch to PF. The operation ***Move*** applies to move syntactic elements to LF and PF where they are checked for semantic interpretation and phonological representation. The output of the ***move operation*** must have sound and meaning representations interpretable by A-P and C-I systems. In the MP, derivations ***converge*** if they are legitimate, i.e., they have been grammatically licensed by ***Feature checking***.

Chomsky (2004), collapsing the expression ***Feature checking*** as ***feature valuation***, submits that ***features*** come in two guises: ***Interpretable Features (iF)*** and ***Uninterpretable features*** (***uF***). Uninterpretable feature enters a derivation unvalued whereas interpretable features have specific values:

> an uninterpretable feature F must be distinguished somehow in LEX from interpretable features. The simplest way, introducing no new devices, is to enter F without value: for

example, [uNumber]. That is particularly natural because the value is redundant, determined by Agree. (Chomsky 2004:116)

Citko (2014:14) differentiates between interpretable and uninterpretable features using *val* ***(feature value)***:

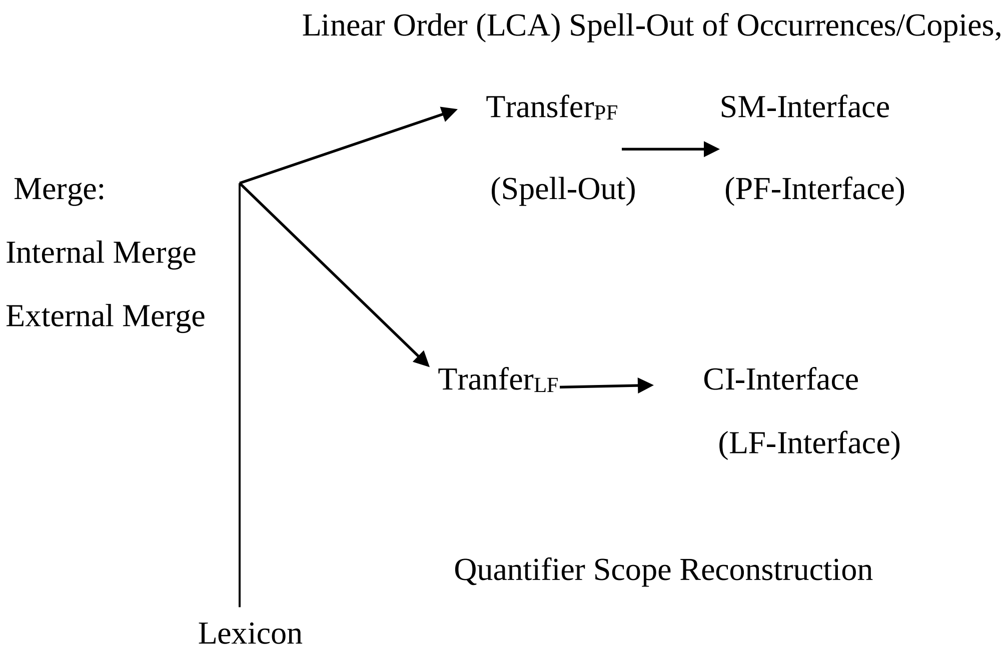
a. Interpretable feature: ***iF***$_{[val]}$ (eg iT$_{[past]}$, i$\varphi_{[3sg,masc]}$)

b. Uninterpretable feature: ***uF*** $_{[\ ]}$ (e.g. uCase $_{[\ ],}$ uφ $_{[\ ]}$)

Crucially, a feature is not interpretable and uninterpretable all by itself and at the same time. The position or interface is a strong factor. It can be interpretable in a position and not in another. For example, φ-features are interpretable on nouns and not on verbs, hence, the conclusion that verbs agree with nouns and not the other way round. According to Kwokwo (2012:44), ***feature checking*** is "a process of checking categorial features such as case, and morphological features of ***Agr*** and tense of lexical items against the corresponding functional categories of *Agrs/ Agro* and tense." The need to check features is premeditated on the assumption that derivation of structures is dependent on the relation specifier and head. In the MP, what used to be known as case assignment is now "case (feature) checking. The emphasis that MP lays to feature checking is not unconnected to Chomsky's introduction of the "unified X-Bar theoretical terms" under Spec-head agreement and based on the theory of inflection. An important addition of the unified X-Bar is the ***Agr Feature***, an assemblage of phi (ф) features of gender, number and person. The manifestation of these features is seen in subject-verb, subject-object and verb-object relations. Hence, Agr checks the case of arguments which had been combined at the operations merge. Nweya (2018: 40) notes that Agr is a formal mechanism for feature valuation and deletion of others (i.e. uninterpretable features). *Agr* establishes a relation between two distinct elements in the syntactic structure through which feature values can be exchanged. There is a higher one and a lower one. The higher one is called the ***probe*** while the lower one is called a ***goal*** (See Radford 2009).

Perhaps, the strongest relevance of the feature checking is to minimize the possibility that a derivation might *crash*. It seeks to ensure that derivations *converge* at PF and LF.

The schema for the architecture of the Minimalist Program is given below.



(Collins 2016:24)

Figure 4 is the Schema for the Architecture of the MP

Fundamentally too, the MP projects a critical assumption known as ***Headedness Principle.*** The headedness principle holds that every syntactic structure is a projection of a *head word.* This explains why clauses and phrases are seen as projections or expansions of head words. Lexical heads like verbs or nouns and functional heads like complementizer, determiner, Agr or tense, negation combine to form Verb Phrase (VP), Noun Phrase (NP), Prepositional Phrase (PP), Complementizer phrase (CP), Determiner Phrase (DP), Tensed Phrase (TP), Agreement Phrase (AgrP) or even Negation Phrase (NegP). These phrases, are formed in bottom-to-top-manner in the MP.

On the basis of this, the study will account for how all the ellipsis kinds selected for this study projected from different heads before they were checked, deemed uninterpretable and deleted at PF interface.

2.2.1.1. Merchant's theoretical assumption on ellipsis licensing within the Minimalist Framework

As established in the previous sections of this study, different scholars have interrogated the ellipsis phenomenon from different perspective ranging from the structural, non-structural, copy theory of movement, to discourse approaches. This present study borrows ideas from Merchant's (2001) **PF-deletion** approach expressed in his **E-Feature** assumptions of the ellipsis phenomenon. This theory is an approach to the cross-linguistic debates on ellipsis licensing within the Minimalist Program. Hence, the core operations of the MP still drive the analysis of this study. The E-feature is defined such that it has a particular semantics, and, in addition, a phonological effect, triggering deletion.

2.2.1.1.1. PF deletion Process

The PF deletion approach holds that the ellipsis site has a fully-fledged syntactic structure that suffers deletion sometime in the derivation. At such, structures that contain ellipsis site and their non-elliptical counterparts are identical except at PF interface. (See Chomsky and Lasnik 1993; Lasnik 2001, 2006a, 2007; Merchant 2001, 2008a; Aelbrecht 2010; van Craenenbroeck 2010).

2.2.1.1.2. The E-Feature

Merchant (2001) provides a condition for deletion in his ***E-Feature*** theory of ellipsis. The theory establishes both semantic and syntactic identities for the relevant parts of the structure for phonological deletion. According to Merchant (2001: 61), "the E-feature imposes on the elided constituent the Focus Condition, based on Givenness, that is, the E-Givenness condition." [E] is responsible for imposing the licensing condition on ellipsis. [E] causes its complement (including everything dominated by that complement) to be elided

Thus, the fundamental relation between the licensing category and the ellipsis site should be maintained in a local head-head relation rather than specifier-head relation.

E-Givenness:

If a constituent, α, is not F-marked, α must be given. An expression *E* counts as *e-Given* iff *E* has a salient antecedent *A* and modulo 3-type shifting,

i. *A* entails *F-clo(E)*, and

ii. *E* entails *F-clo(A)*

(Merchant, 2001: 26)

The above holds that any material(s) targeted for deletion, such material, ***E***, must be a ***given*** information which entails that it must have already appeared somewhere in the preceding discourse, i.e. in the antecedent. New information, if found, has to be ***F-Marked*** and if not, is assumed to be ***given*** in the antecedent. The antecedent triggers ***F-Closure*** of the ***[E]***, i.e. ensures they have the same *entailment*, just as ***E*** also triggers the ***F-Closure*** of ***A***. He however, adds that if *E* combines with IP, a failure to delete, due to **Focus Condition,** should be treated as a presupposition failure (2000: 61). It means that the meaning of *E* can be expressed with a partial identity function as seen below.

$||E|| = \lambda p$: p is e-Given. P

(Merchant 2001: 61)

Gengel (2007) opines that should a semantic definition be given to *E*, then it would mean that the licensing processes are related in one single feature. Here, the licensing process has to do with the featural requirement that *E* involves while the identification process is the semantic condition that *E* exerts on its complement or the maximal projection on whose head it is placed. This ensures that the two processes involved in the derivation of ellipsis are licensed. To suit this, Gengel (2007), using Rooth's (1992 a,b) terminology, rephrased Merchants (2001) *E-Givenness* and meaning of *E* in and *focus condition* above . We see the changes below.

Focus Condition on Ellipsis

A constituent **α** in XP_E can be deleted only if there is an XP_A, where:

i. $||XP_A||$ either is or implies an element of $||XP_E||^f$, and

ii. $||XP_E||^o$ either is or implies an element of $||XP_A||^f$

(Gengel 2007:226)

$||E|| = \lambda p$: p satisfies the **Focus condition on Ellipsis.**

(Gengel 2007:226)

The above simply implies, in addition to Merchant's assumptions, that the presence or absence of a ***focused*** material(s) is a strong variable of whether ellipsis can happen or not, i.e. the condition on which a material can elided is defined in terms of ***focus*** and not only ***Givenness.*** She proposes that there be an interaction between both. This is important to this study as we will deploy this interaction in determining the conditions for ellipsis between the languages under investigation.

Merchant notes that there also has to be locality restrictions between the E-Feature and the deleted constituents in order to account for ellipsis. However, he adds that there are bound to be cross-linguistic variations of elliptical structures owing to the assumption that the features against which the E-Feature is checked may vary from one language to the other. In his words, (2000: 61), "this particular implementation leaves open the exact nature and number of the feature and requirements of E to be checked, allowing for cross-linguistic variation in this domain, if necessary."

In a different study, Merchant (2004:671) argues that the phonological effect of the E-Feature is the same across languages irrespective of cross-linguistic variations in the configuration of the E-Feature bearing in mind that the E-feature triggers phonological deletion of the complement of the head on which it is placed. An example is seen in (35) below using sluicing which is argued as TP deletion. In sluicing, the effect of the E-Feature can be summarized below.

The Phonology of E

$\varphi_{TP} \longrightarrow Ø/E\_$

where φTP indicates the material that the TP node dominates.

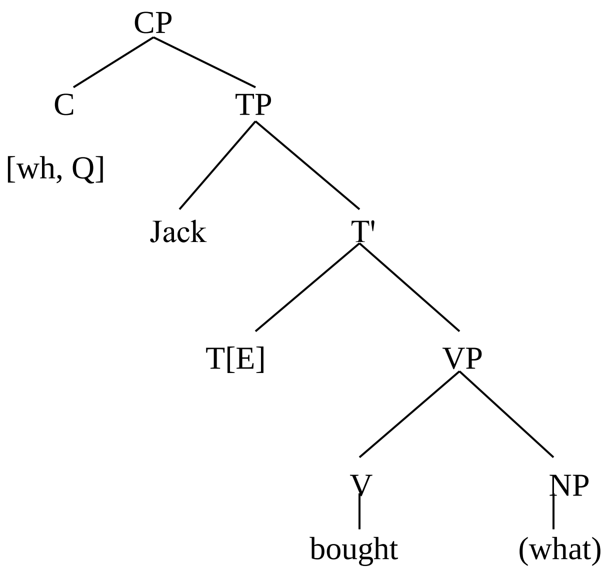
(Merchant, 2004: 671)

Here, as provided for sluicing, the complementizer **C** merges with **E,** yielding **TP** deletion. Put more specifically, the E-Feature is placed first on the head **I**. Because Feature checking involves movement, it moves from **I** to **C** where it is checked against the [+wh,+Q] features on the C head, and hence, triggers deletion of the sister of **C**. Alternatively, the E-Feature could be placed on the C head immediately, being the subject to a *feature compatibility requirement.* Merchant (2001:58) demonstrating this process in sluicing gives the example (35) below.

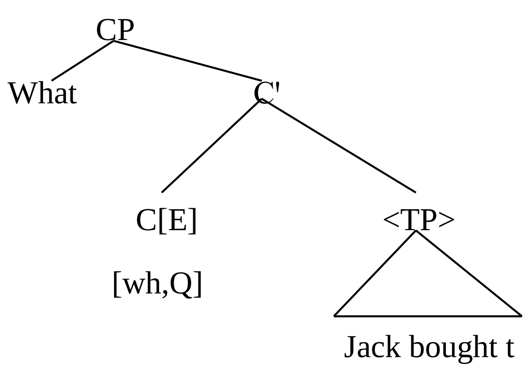
35. Jack bought something, but I don’t know what Ø

The E-Feature in the above for sluicing is specified as being [+wh+Q]. It is generated in T as shown in the tree diagram (36) below and moves up to C shown in (37) where its Wh features are checked. In C, it then instructs its sister node <TP>, to delete, yielding the sluiced example in (38). See the description below.

36.



37.



38. Jack bought something, but I don’t know what [~~Jack bought~~]

Hence, sluicing, here is possible having fulfilled the *Focus Condition for Ellipsis* earlier mentioned. This *Focus Condition* is rephrased for sluicing below.

Focus Condition on TP-Deletion (Sluicing):

A ***TP*** **α** can be deleted only if **α** is *e-GIVEN.*

(Merchant, 2001: 57)

The above provides that for a syntactic structure ***α*** (a TP that begins with a **wh complementizer** in this particular case of sluicing) to be deleted, such ***wh*** syntactic structure **α** has to be entailed (***e-given***) in the antecedent syntactic structure and hence recoverable from such antecedent clause.

The application of this E-Feature to other types of elliptical structures selected for this study will be treated in Chapter four of this work.

2.2.1.1.3. The E-Feature and Focus

With reference to the Focusing condition on ellipsis and E-Features above, it would be appropriate to argue that the condition on which materials can be elided depends on the presence or absence of ***Focused material*** in the elided part of the clause. Gengel (2007:226) proposes that E-feature "be sensitive to the notion of Givenness or Focus." She therefore modifies the definition of the E-Feature on the basis of Focus. See (39).

39. ||E|| = λp: p satisfies the *Focus Condition on Ellipsis*.

P and E does not apply to *Focused Material (F-marked)*

She observes that the definition of the above can be understood from a semantic and syntactic point of view. On the semantic side, the information in the E-Feature and ellipsis site is very clear or implicit. The syntactic side operates on the assumption that since the E-Feature specifies the deletion of the syntactic complement of the on which it is placed, no focused material should be (or remain) within the syntactic domain of the E-Feature. Therefore, it would be concluded that the E-Feature and the Focused (Feature) Material interact to yield and movement and deletion account of ellipsis. To emphasize, when the E-Feature has specified a part of the structure to be deleted, the focused material has to be moved out prior to deletion.

In this study, we intend to find out how the E-feature and Focused material interact and in deciding what can or cannot be elided.

2.3. Justification of the Theoretical Framework

As already established above, the MP is adopted as the theoretical framework for this study. This choice is predicated on MP's emphasis the economy of derivation principles and other universally applicable principles of language to track their idiosyncratic parameters. This is usually achieved by a very powerful tool of the MP known as Feature Checking and Licensing. This study takes full advantage of this provision by the MP to look out for how the features of elliptical structures are checked and licensed between the two languages chosen for this study

The study is specifically guided by Merchant's (2001) **E-Feature and Givenness** theory of ellipsis. Merchant's (2001) account is an approach to the ellipsis debates. It is fundamentally founded on the core provisions and operations of the MP like feature checking and licensing, merging, movement, agree relations, and the interplay between interpretable and uninterpretable features. These operations are genetically found in the MP, so, the MP constitutes the theoretical underpinning for this study but aided by Merchant's account. This is on the grounds that the approach, within the confines of the MP, provides an account of the licensing condition for ellipsis that puts both the syntax and semantics of elliptical structures into consideration and allows room for cross-linguistic variations. This foregrounds the reality that the basic assumption of the theory could be applied to various languages of the world to ascertain the extent that the E-Feature can go in triggering phonological deletion of structures in the ellipsis site. Our data will be checked against the E-Feature and Focus Feature to determine the strength of the features in both English and Igbo, and eventually guide us to our conclusions which will in turn be in improving and facilitating the pedagogical grammar of English.

2.4. Summary

In line with this focus of this study, this chapter has presented a review of related works on the ellipsis phenomenon. In doing the reviews, conceptual clarifications were made. Clear distinctions were also made on the selected ellipsis types with little backup data from the literature. The chapter also reviewed some empirical studies on ellipsis and others on CA. These reviews are important as they shed light on existing studies on ellipsis and CA and help to define the gap that this present study intends to fill. Other conceptual issues considered important to the work were also reviewed. Finally, the chapter shed some light on the chosen theoretical underpinning for the study and went ahead to justify the choice of theory. The next chapter is devoted to the methodology adopted for the study.

CHAPTER THREE

METHODOLOGY

3.1. Introduction

This chapter presents the principles that defined the conduct of the investigation made in this study. It captures the steps the researcher took in finding the answers to the research questions. First, the chapter highlighted the research design, followed by study area, study population, sampling size, research instruments, data collection procedure and finally ended with method of data analysis.

3.2. Research design

Research design according to Resinger (2009:36) "is the actual structure according to which a study is organized." It is the framework or scaffold around which we organize a study. As it has to do with this work, qualitative and descriptive research designs were adopted in this study. The study is on a survey to describe the elliptical structures of both English and Igbo with a view to tracking their similarities and differences. Hence, the adopted research design satisfies the overall methods of data gathering and analysis for the study. The sentences described were elicited from natural Igbo speakers. The descriptions were to show that constituents in structures were either elided or not, judging from what is permitted in the language.

3.3. Study area

The study is geographically limited to Igboland, Nigeria. The study specifically selected some areas of Abia State which are Aba South, Aba North, Osisioma, Obingwa, Ugwunagbo, Umuahia North and Umuahia South towns. The Standard Igbo also known by some as Central Igbo or *Igbo Izugbe* (the chosen variety for this study) is spoken widely in this aforementioned places owing to the fact that they are largely populated areas with people from different parts of Igboland hence, the need to speak the Central Igbo for ease of communication.

3.4. Study population

The population for this study was drawn from the natural or indigenous speakers of Igbo from the geographical areas mentioned in section 3.3 above.

3.5. Population sample

The non-probalistic sampling method, specifically, the purposive sampling technique was adopted for this study. The convenience of selecting our informants, respondents, consultants and research assistants based on our knowledge and conviction of them as individuals capable of providing information needed for this study was put to use in this study. Twelve adult speakers within the age range of twenty-five to fifty-five were purposively selected across the study area. While six of them were bilinguals, being able to speak English and Igbo, the other six were monolinguals (speak only Igbo). Two of the six bilinguals were experts in Igbo linguistics studies having studied the Igbo language extensively and taught same across secondary schools and a university in Abia state.

They were purposively selected as research consultants /assistants for this study. They were saddled with the responsibility of validating the data elicited from the other respondents. The researcher trusted their grammaticality judgement since they were both indigenous speakers and language experts of Igbo.

The researcher himself was also part of the population sample for the study since he is also a native speaker of Igbo. He deployed his native-speaker intuition in passing grammaticality judgement too. The researcher's judgement was, however, subjected to further validation by other speakers of Igbo, especially, research consultants and assistants.

3.6. Research instruments

As the study's objectives have necessitated, the research instruments employed are In-depth Interviews (IDI) and Participant Observations (PO). These instruments were effectively used to elicit expressions in Igbo from the respondents with a view to tracking whether sentence constituents were elided or not. This gave insight into the ellipsis types attested and the ones that were not attested in Igbo. Using the instrument of Participant Observation, the researcher prompted the respondents into conversations and question/answer sessions. The sessions were recorded with a mobile phone device and the responses from the respondents were transcribed.

3.7. Method of data collection

Two methods of data collection were adopted for this study: primary and secondary methods.

- **Primary method**

The bulk of the data for Igbo were got through the primary method. Techniques deployed in this method included guided oral interviews, observation and personal introspection. The researcher's judgement, guided by introspection was further subjected to validation by the Igbo linguists (research consultants). To find out whether the selected elliptical structures were attested in Igbo as they are in English, the researcher, guided by the English data (Lobeck, 1995; Kester, 1996; Merchants, 2001; Johnson, 2004; Arregui, et al 2006; Gengel, 2007; Kertz, 2010; Algryani, 2012 and Bevis, 2018) prepared context-based questions that required that the respondents elided some constituents in their sentence responses as they rendered them in Igbo. The expressions used by the researcher to contextualize the questions were such that a part of the message would have been mentioned earlier in the same expression (recall: *antecedent clause)* and hence needed to be elided since such messages were recoverable from context. This was designed across all selected ellipsis types for this study.

In guided oral interviews, with the researcher keenly observing as to track instances where constituents were elided, these questions were posed to the bilingual respondents first and their responses, in Igbo, were elicited and recorded using a mobile phone device. The monolingual respondents were also guided through context-based explanations to do same. Their responses were also elicited and recorded.

The bulk of the data assembled were sent to the two experts at Igbo language for reassessment and validation. The data was also revalidated with the Igbo monolingual respondents. These were all in a bid to ensure that valid native-speaker grammaticality judgement had been passed on ellipsis licensing in Igbo.

- **Secondary source**

The English data were sourced from published and unpublished empirical studies on ellipsis especially in the native English speaker contexts. The English data were got from (Lobeck, 1995; Kester, 1996; Merchants, 2001; Johnson, 2004; Arregui et al 2006, Gengel, 2007; Kertz, 2010; Algryani, 2012 and Bevis, 2018). Depending on secondary data from these studies was because, first, the present researcher is not a native speaker and also no native speaker was available to supply primary data as at the time of carrying out this research.

3.8. Method of data analysis

The data were collated with respect to the selected elliptical types for this study. They were sorted and descriptively analysed. Attention was paid to the constituents that were elided or not elided and the grammaticality or ungrammaticality of the sentences where elisions happened in both English and Igbo. After the analysis of each ellipsis type, contrastive statements were made to show areas of similarities or differences in both languages. The analysis was guided by theoretical provisions of the Minimalist Program.

3.9. Summary

This chapter has provided insight into the steps that were undertaken towards conducting this research. It gave an overview of the research design, study area, population sample, size and research instruments, and explained how the data were collected and analysed. The next chapter will engage the data in a syntactic demonstration.

CHAPTER FOUR

VP-ELLIPSIS, FRAGMENT ELLIPSIS AND NP-ELLIPSIS IN ENGLISH AND IGBO

4.0. Introduction

This chapter discusses VP-ellipsis, fragments and NP-ellipsis in English and Igbo. Basically, it focuses on identifying the syntactic features of the aforementioned ellipsis types in both languages as well as exploring the divergences in their licensing conditions. It goes further to make contrastive statements after each analysis in order to point out the similarities and differences in these licensing conditions. This is with a view to improving the teaching and learning of English to Igbo speakers of English in Nigeria.

4.1. VP-Ellipsis in English

We define VP ellipsis as a syntactic phenomenon where the verb and every constituent following it is deleted leaving only the discourse linker *too* as remnant. The ellipsis site is always preceded by an auxiliary element or modal. Johnson (2008a) argues for the structural approach in VP ellipsis. He posits that there is a fully-fledged syntactic material(s) present in the ellipsis site. This syntactic material, however, goes unpronounced at PF or Spell-Out. The argument for a syntactic material in the ellipsis site takes advantage of anaphoric relations which allow for certain information in a discourse to be given and thereafter, deaccented. Information is said to be given if it is already introduced somewhere in the discourse. So, where this information is given, it becomes more convenient to deaccent, i.e. remove the phonological pitch or accent from a following constituent. See the example below.

1. **a. Andrew drives a new car.**
   b. No, *Andrew drives* an OLD *car*.

In (1b), the italicized part of the whole sentence has been deaccented because the information has already been supplied in (1a). *Old* is new information and that is why it is not deaccented. Armed with this facts, Johnson (2008: 5) defines VP-ellipsis as “that type of radical deaccenting where elided materials have been deaccented right into silence.” This implies that even though the deleted part of the derivation is not pronounced, the syntactic elements are still overt.

To further prove that the syntactic elements in the ellipsis site is full-fledged, one would observe that there is still agreement in number and tense between the antecedent clause and target clause. See the example below.

2. a. **Joe didn't know he would find a man in the room,** but *there was.* ~~a man in the room~~

   b. * **Joe didn't know he would find a man in the room,** but *there were.* ~~a man in the room~~

(2b) is ungrammatical because, even though the italicized sentences have expletive subjects *there*, the subject of the embedded clause, *a man,* (bold typed) controls the number agreement on the verbs as in (2a) where *a man* and *was* are both singular. This is not the case in (2b), hence, the ungrammaticality.

Movement also proves that there is/are syntactic structure(s) in the ellipsis sites. van Craenenbroeck and Merchant (2013:706) have deeply interrogated the possibility of extraction out of the ellipsis site. They note that VP-ellipsis is possible in passives, unaccusatives and raising constructions as exemplified in (3 a-c), respectively.

3. a. **John was arrested** and *Bill was* ~~arrested~~ *too*.

   b. **John arrived at the party** before *Nikita did.* ~~arrive at the party~~

   c. **John seems to be happy,** but *Mary doesn't*. ~~seem to be happy~~

The above construction kinds prove that movement of a VP-internal argument to the VP-external object position [SpecT], i.e., moving a DP out of the elided VP is grammatical. Furthermore, A^{I} movement out of the ellipsis site is grammatical. See examples (4a-d).

4. a. **I know which books you like** and *which ones you don't.* ~~like~~

   b. **Potatoes I like,** but *tomatoes I don't.* ~~like~~

   c. **Give me the books you like** and *the ones you don't.* ~~like~~

   d. **A nurse will examine every patient** and *a doctor will* ~~examine every patient~~ *too.*

(van Craenenbroeck and Merchant 2013:706)

In (4a), a wh-phrase was extracted out of the elided VP in the second conjunct. In (4b), the NP, *tomatoes,* was topicalized and moved out of the elided VP. In (4c), the DP, *the ones,* was extracted from the ellipsis site and in (4d), the QP, *every patient* was moved out of the ellipsis site through quantifier raising so that it can scoop over the subject DP of the elliptical clause.

4.1.2. Syntax and semantics identity in VP-Ellipsis

The fundamental issue here is whether the antecedent clause and the target clause have to be matched in structure or meaning. To account for this, syntactic and semantic mismatch between the antecedent and ellipsis site has been robustly studied in the literature. The invested attention has been to interrogate which is more tolerated. The bulk of the data in English has shown that syntactic mismatches are more tolerated than the semantic ones, hence there has to always be a relationship between the antecedent and the ellipsis site. For example, syntactic mismatch between an active antecedent and a passive target clause in structures with VP-ellipsis maintain grammaticality even though there is a passive antecedent and an active ellipsis site as example (5) shows.

5. a. The janitor must remove the trash whenever it is apparent that it should. ~~be removed~~.

   b. The system can be used by anyone who wants. ~~to use the system~~

This is because the truth-conditional semantics of active and passive sentences are identical. This further proves that the antecedent and target clauses are more semantically related than they are syntactically.

4.1.3. Licensing of VP-Ellipsis

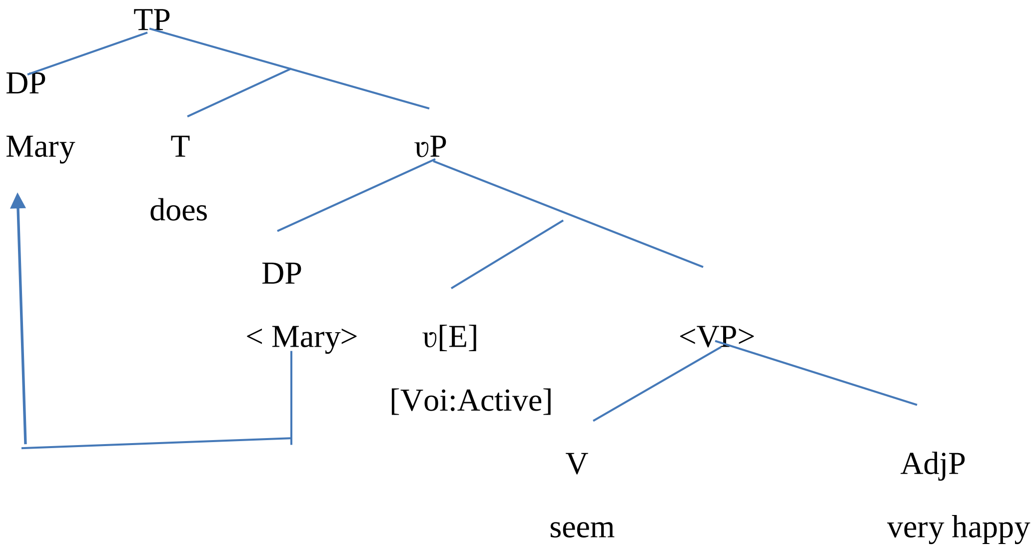
Merchant's (2001:60) E-Feature for VP-ellipsis holds that:

*A VP **α** can be deleted if and only if **α** is **e-given**.*

So, to license VP-ellipsis the E-Feature must be placed on T as the licensing head. When placed there, it instructs the deletion of complements of the TP i.e. the VP. However, in line with the current Split VP projections, where there is a ʋP projection above VP, Merchant (2007) suggests that the E-Feature be placed on **voice head**, that is on **ʋ** rather than on T. This is so that VP ellipsis allows for voice alternation.

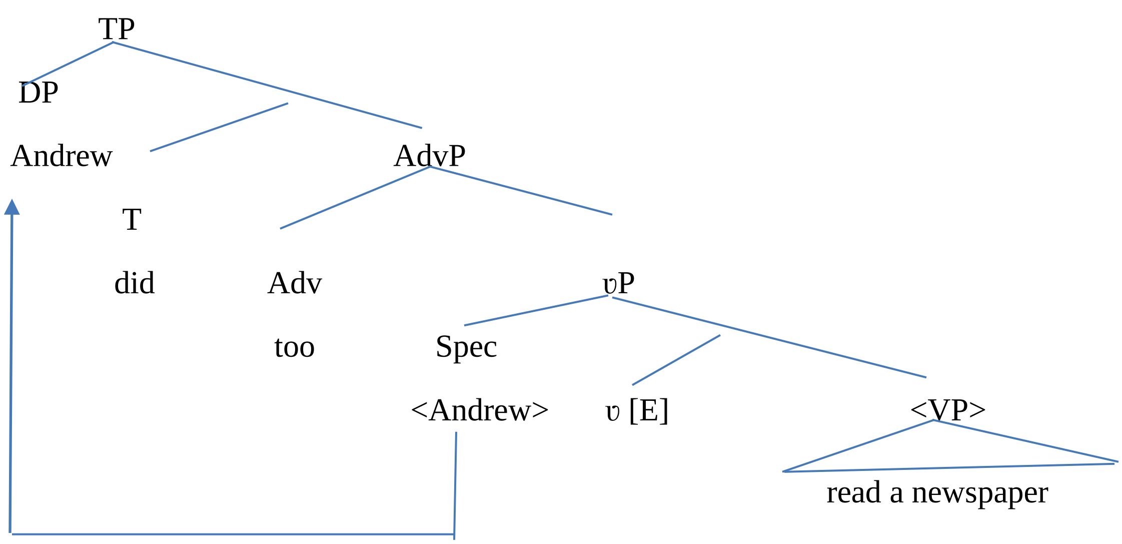
See the following examples on a tree diagram.

6. **John doesn't seems very happy**, but *Mary does*. ~~seem very happy~~



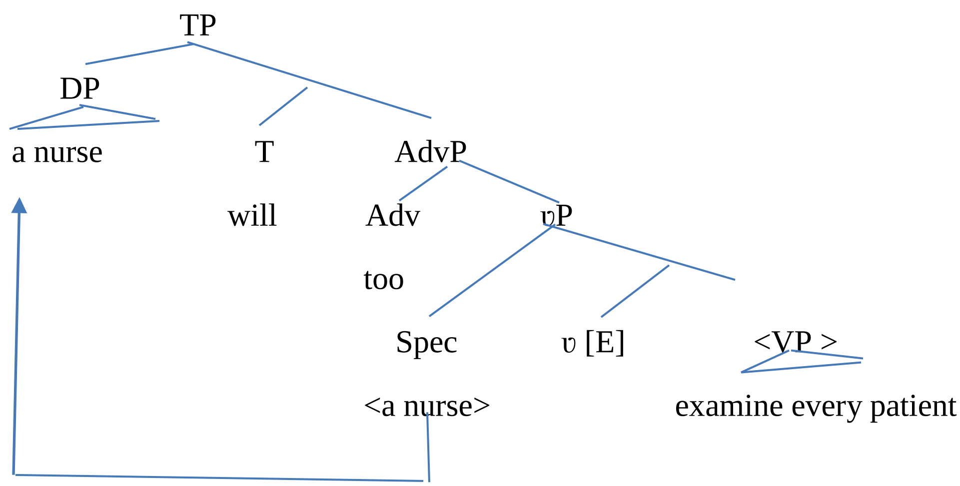
In example (6) above, the VP-ellipsis site (target clause) has been put on a diagrammatic representation to show that the auxiliary *does* has licensed the deletion of the VP constituent, *seem very happy*. The E-Feature was derived on node **υ**, the voice head, and thereafter, triggered deletion of the sister constituent. The DP *Mary* originally derived at Specυ was moved to SpecTP for EPP condition after its case features were checked by the strong features of +Tns and +num on T.

7. **John read a newspaper** and *Andrew did* ~~read a newspaper~~ *too*.



(7) above also shows the same deletion process like (6). The [E] Feature disallowed the parsing of the VP constituents, thereby instructing that they be deleted at PF. Observe that (7) has another maximal projection where the discourse linker, *too* was hosted.

8. **A doctor will examine every patient** and *a nurse will* ~~examine every patient~~ *too*.



The E-Feature has been used to demonstrate that VP-Ellipsis is largely attested in the English data. Observe that in all the examples, the information elided in the VPs were ***e-given***, that is, already established in the context and hence recoverable from such context. The reason for the deletion at PF (null Pronouncement of constituents) may be for faster and more convenient speaking.

4.2. VP-Ellipsis in Igbo

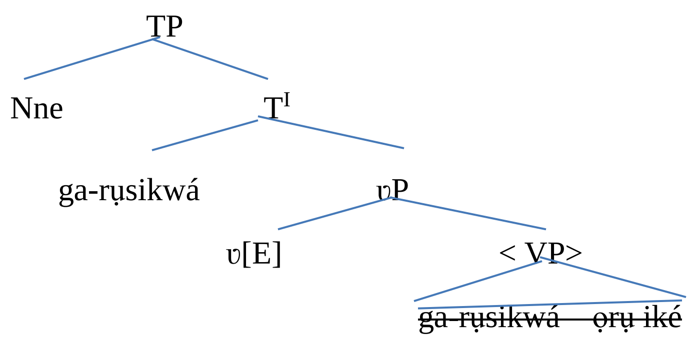
VP-ellipsis is attested in Igbo. However, there are modifications to its licensing conditions. Our data shows that auxiliaries and modals can license VP ellipsis in Igbo but this has some parametric permutations. I-Languages differ in the configuration of their inflectional, auxiliary, and morphological systems. Igbo is not an exception. Nwakwegwu (2015) posits that one needs to look inside words in order to understand their complete semantic import in Igbo because certain pieces of information are encoded morphologically instead of lexically in Igbo. The negative, perfective aspectual, main verbal, modal auxiliaries and other information notions are inflectionally conflated into one verbal complex. That is to say that it is normal to merge modals and other materials with the lexical verb in Igbo. Hence, Igbo is an agglutinative language by morphological typological standard (Nwakwegwu, 2015). This can be seen in the examples below where the auxiliaries and adverb discourse linker *kwa* (too) are inflected in a bound manner with the lexical verbs and therefore it becomes difficult to show that the auxiliaries which are normally derived on head T for having strong features of + Tns and Num licensed the deletion of the verb and its complement. Hence, the whole materials are hosted or raised to head T because the verb element, having become bound with the auxiliary and the discourse linker *kwa* is not obligatorily deleted but moves to spell-out. We posit that VP-deletion has, however, actually been covertly obtained at LF since the rest of the materials in the VP domain gets deleted.

Consider the following examples.

9. a. **Nnà rụsiri ọrụ iké**; *Nnè ga-rụsikwá.* ~~ọrụ iké~~
   Nnà work PST job hard Nnè will-workASP-FUT-too job hard.
   'Nnà worked very hard and Nnè will too.'

10. a. **Nnà gụrụ ákwukwọ ákụkọ**; *Nnè kwesiri-ịgụkwá.* ~~ákwụkwọ ákụkọ~~.
   Nná readPST book news Nnè should-readASP-FUT-too book news.
   'Nnà read a newspaper and Nne should too'

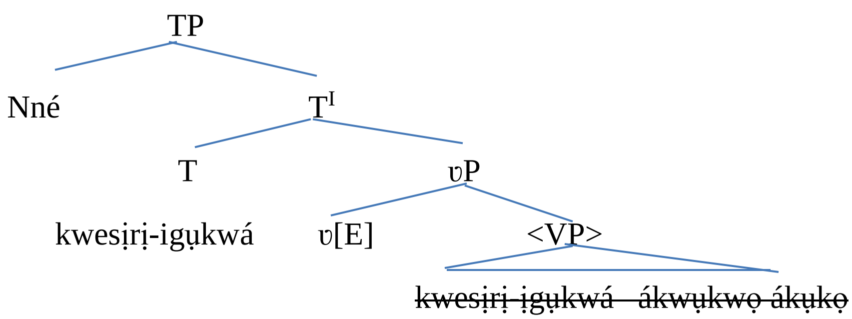
9. b. **Nnà rusiri ọrụ iké**; *Nnè ga-rụsikwá.* ~~ọrụ iké~~.[4]



[4] We have only shown the tree configuration of the conjuncts since the materials here are the ones targeted for deletion.

In (9b) above, the E-Feature that is placed on ʋ, the voice head, triggers deletion of the VP *ga-rụsikwá ọrụ ike*. However, as established above, the auxiliary *ga* and the discourse linker *kwa* are inseparably conflated with the lexical verb *rụ* such that the whole materials are hosted on head T before the deletion takes place. The verb deletion happened at LF since it moves to spell-out. Only the complement in the VP domain goes unpronounced at PF.

10b. **Nnà gụrụ ákwukwọ ákụkọ**; *Nnè kwesịrị-igụkwá*. ~~ákwụkwọ ákụkọ~~



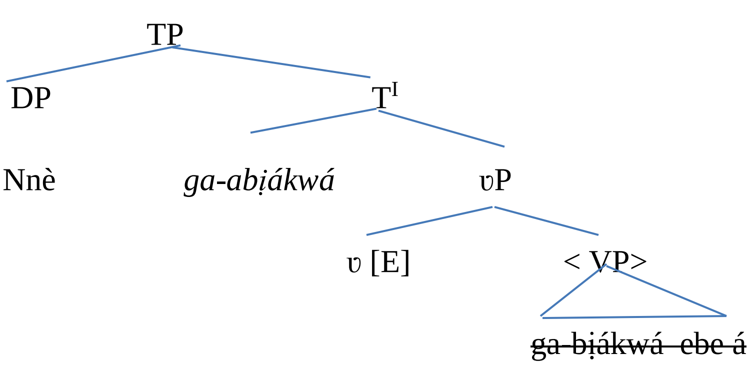
Again, the E-Feature on the voice head in (10b) triggered the deletion of its VP sister constituents *kwesịrị-igụkwá ákwụkwọ ákụkọ*. The auxiliary *kwesịrị* and the discourse linker *kwa* have been conflated with the verb *gụ* such that all the materials are raised to head T for spell-out while the remaining constituents on the VP get deleted.

11a. **Nnà** **bịarà** **ebe á**; *Nnè* *ga-abịákwá*. ~~ebe á~~

Nnà comePST here Nnè will-comeASP-FUT-too here

'Nnà came here and Nne will too.'

11b.



In (11a) as shown in (11b) the adverbial complement of the VP *ebe á* is deleted at the PF interface since it does not move to spell out. However, the auxiliary, *ga*, lexical, *bịá*, and the discourse linker, *kwá*, having become merged, together move to spell out on T head.

Examples (12) and (13) below show the same deletion process in labelled brackets.

12. **Nnà áhụghị onyé ọbụla** mana *Nnè nwèrèike-ịhụ*. ~~mmadụ~~.

Nnà seeNEG anyone but Nnè may-seeASP-FUT someone

'Nnà didn't see anyone but Nnè may.'

[TP [DP Nnè] [T ^{I}[T *nwèrèike-ịhụ*][ʋP [ʋ [E][<VP ~~*nwèrèike-ịhụ* mmadụ~~ >]]]]

The labelled brackets for (12) have also shown that the VP *nwèrèike-ịhụ mmadụ* was deleted but as determined by the language feature, the verb *ịhụ* survives this deletion since it is carrying other important information like the auxiliary *nwèrèike* which actually licensed the deletion on head T. Consider (13) below too.

13. **Nnà aga-atànwu ọkwụrụ ndụ** mànà *Nnè gá-atanwu* ~~ya~~.

Nnà canNEG-eat-ASP-APPL okra life but Nnè can eatASP-FUT it

'Nnà can't eat fresh okra but Nnè can eat it'

[TP [DP Nnè] [T^{I}] [T gá-atanwu [ʋP[ʋ [E][<VP> ~~gá-atanwu ya~~.]]]]

The above leads us to conclude on the attestation of VP ellipsis in Igbo with its peculiar specifications.

4.3. Contrastive statement

The analyses above have shown that VP-ellipsis is attested in English and Igbo. However, Igbo showed a variation in its licensing condition. In Igbo, the auxiliaries are conflated or merged with the main verbs, making it difficult for the main verb to be deleted at PF but only at LF since its information had been **e-given** in the antecedent clause. Therefore, all the conflated materials are raised to head T, out of the ellipsis site and the complement of the VP gets deleted at PF. This is quite different from how it obtains in the English data where the auxiliaries and modals are independently hosted on head T and the lexical verbs in the ʋP or VP domains, respectively, making it possible for the auxiliary on T to check and delete the constituents in ʋ/VP domain.

4.4. Fragment Ellipsis in English

Fragment ellipsis is the shortening or reduction of full sentential expressions to incomplete linguistic sentences due to haste or convenience of speech. Erschler (2014) acknowledges that languages vary in the ways they allow or not allow fragment questions and answers. He reports that not all languages freely allow fragmentary utterances. Merchant (2004) argues that fragmentary utterances are short answers and subsentential XPs without linguistic antecedents but having fully sentential syntactic structures. In this definition, Merchant (2004) and (2006), Krifka (2006), van Craenenbroeck (2010) amongst others all argue for a structural approach for fragmentary utterances which holds that there are full-fledged syntactic structures in the ellipsis site only that they go unpronounced. Fragmentary utterances or answers are always preceded by some discourse contexts which provide for the antecedents of such short answers. See the examples below.

14. Abby and Ben are at a party. Abby asks Ben about who their mutual friend Beth is bringing as a date by uttering: "Who is Beth bringing?" Ben answers: "Alex."
15. Abby and Ben are at a party. Abby sees an unfamiliar man with Beth, a mutual friend of theirs, and turns to Ben with a puzzled look on her face. Ben says: "Some guy she met at the park."

(Merchant 2004:661)

Observe that in each of (14) and (15) above, the utterances (answers) are preceded by some discourse contexts that either included or did not include linguistic material(s). (14) includes a linguistic material to the fragmentary utterance while the fragmentary response in (15) is given to a non-verbalized facial expression. The lexical content of both utterances are DPs but can be used to advance a discourse in the same way like full sentential utterances, which actually implies that they have the same assertoric force and propositional contents like full-fledged sentences as shown in examples (c) of (16) to (20) below.

16. a. Who did she see?

    b. John.

    c. She saw John.

17. a. When did he leave?

b. After the movie ended.

c. He left after the movie ended.

18. a. What does Bush want to do to Iraq?

b. Attack it.

c. Bush wants to attack it.

19. a. What's that?

b. A dish.

c. It's a dish.

20. a. What's left for me to eat?

b. Some turkey.

c. There's some turkey.

(Merchant 2004:673)

Data (16) to (20) (c) are the full sentential equivalents of the fragmentary utterances in (b). In discourse situations, the fragmentary utterances in (b) carry the same entailments or propositions like the (c) counterparts.

Fragments show grammatical dependencies which is also known as connectivity effects on missing linguistic material. This missing linguistic materials are similar to those in the full, non-elliptical sentential correlates. This connectivity effects can be seen in terms of *morphological case marking, preposition stranding, binding effects, islands, complementizer deletions, polarity items, raising,* and *pronominals.* Examples is seen from many languages like English, Greek, German, Korean, and so on. (21) below is on morphological case marking.

21. Q. a. Whose car did you take?

b. John's

c. *John.

d. I took John’s car.

(Merchant 2004:678)

Example (21c) is ungrammatical because it in the accusative case instead of the genitive case as to be morphologically case-marked the same way with the NP *John’s* in the full sentential equivalent in (d). This has proven that the morphological case in the fragment DP has to be exactly the same as the case that can be found in the DP of the full sentential equivalents.

Furthermore, fragmentary utterances obey the binding principles. This supports the assumption that they are derived from focus movement that happened prior to TP deletions. The DPs in fragments show that they are regulated by the Binding Theory and that the anaphors in fragmentary utterances are grammatical irrespective of the absence of any antecedent(s). Consider (22) to (25) below.

22. a. Who does John like?

b. Himself.

c. John likes himself.

23. a. Who does John think Sue will invite?

b. Himself.

c. John thinks Sue will invite himself.

24. a. Who do they like?

b. Each other.

c. They like each other.

25. a. Who did $John_1$ try to shave?

b. *Him_1.

c. *$John_1$ tried to shave him_1.

(Merchant, 2004:680)

The fragmentary utterances in (22b) to (25b) show that reflexives and reciprocals are parallel to the full sentential equivalents in (c). The ungrammaticality in (25) is hinged on the violation of Principle B effects since *him* cannot be co-indexed with *John* in both (b) and (c).

4.4.1. Licensing of Fragment ellipsis in English

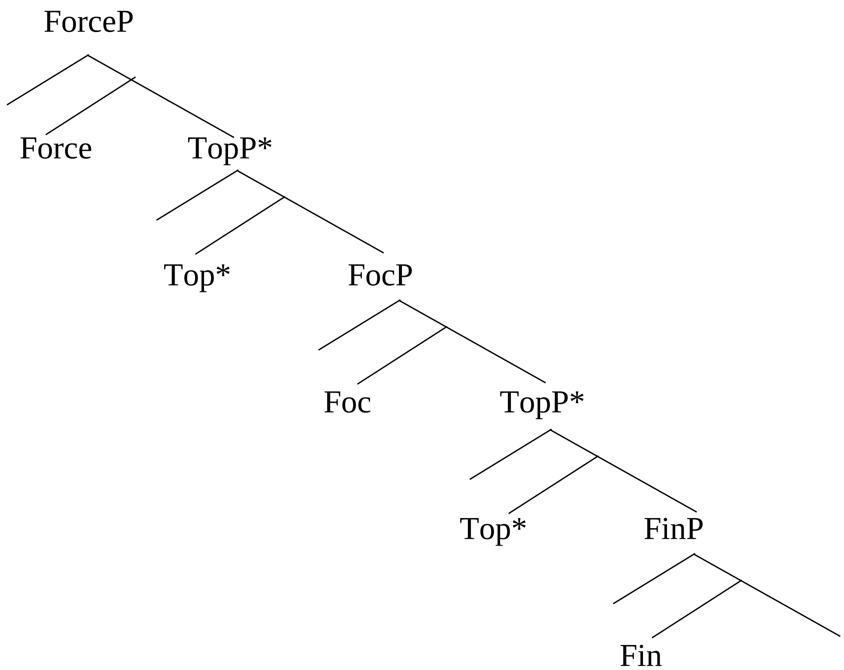
Merchant (2004) suggests that to license fragment ellipsis, the fragmentary utterance moves to a functional projection above TP and thereafter, the TP is deleted. The crucial E-Feature that is responsible for triggering deletion of the TP, has to be placed or derived on the FocHead. Merchant (2004) further argues that the movement of fragmentary expressions are actually A-bar movements/ focus-movements of the left periphery like clitic-left dislocations.

He suggests that this functional projection is in the wake of Rizzi's (1997) *structure of the left periphery* with emphasis on the focus phrase.

Rizzi's (1997) *the Extended Structure of the Left Periphery* provides for projections that are mainly related to discourse functions and the structure of information. Rizzi argues that this structure could be used to account for the ordering of constraints involving the elements of the C-system. Insight from this proposal has attracted scholarly research into the expanded or articulated left periphery across languages. The hypothesis suggests that CP should be split into a number of different projections: **ForceP, TopicP, FocusP** and **FiniteP**. It holds that complementizers, because of their role specifying whether a given clause is declarative, interrogative, imperative or exclamative should be derived on Node Force (specifier of ForceP). **Focused constituents** should be hosted on **FocP** (**Focus Phrase)** (Radford 2009).

On the lower level, the clause left periphery is assumed to project **FinP** (Finite Phrase), the locus of finiteness. The focused constituents are emphasised within a clause and carry **Edge Feature** which makes it possible that they attract cyclic maximal projections to move to specifier of FocP. Below is the split CP Hypothesis schema.

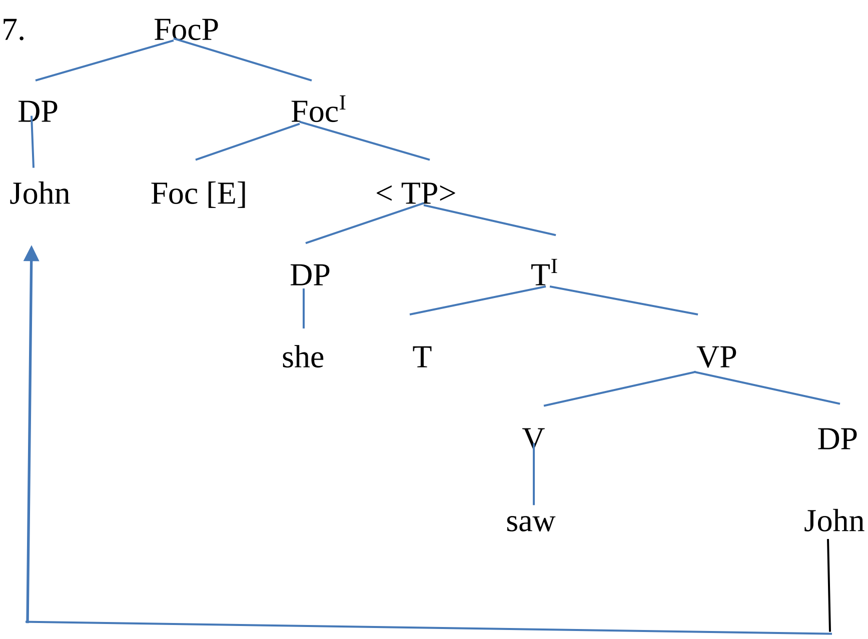
26.



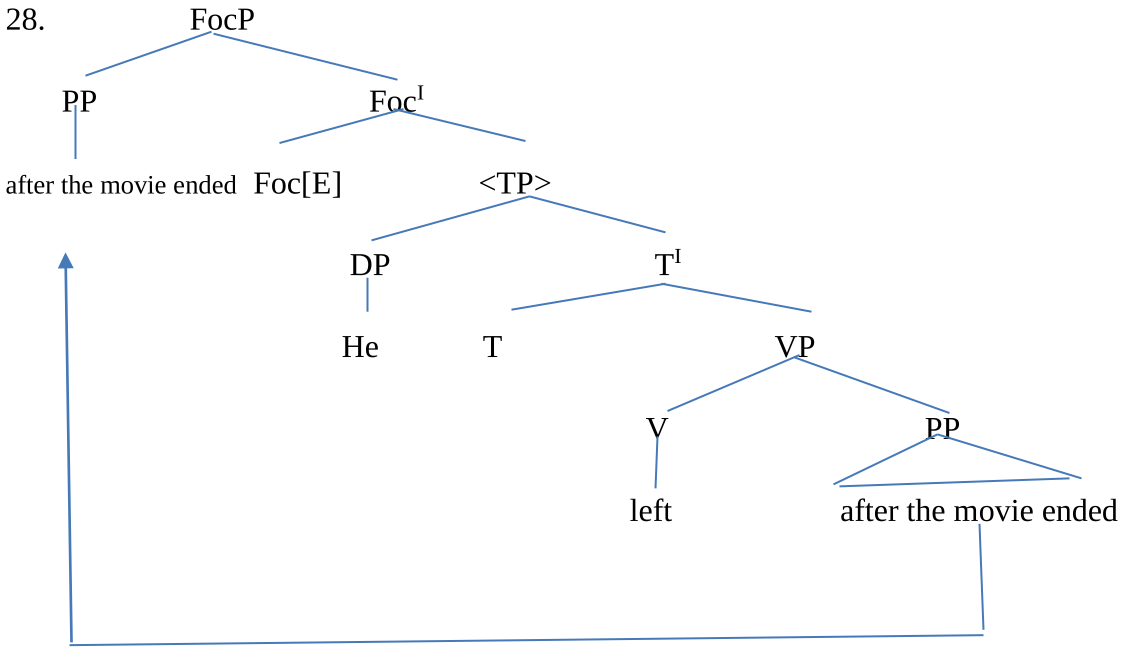
(Rizzi 1997:297)

We provide the following configurations to illustrate the above assumptions in fragments. The full-sentential correlates of the fragmentary utterances in (16) and (17) above are diagrammatically represented in (27) and (28) below to show the deletion process as well as the focus movement.

27.



28.



The configurations above show that the fragment answers, functioning in the capacity of TP ellipsis remnants, were moved maximally to FocP out of the ellipsis site prior to the deletion that was triggered by the E-Feature. In (27) the DP *John* was functionally moved out of the ellipsis site since it is the fragmentary utterance in the TP while the PP *after the movie ended* was moved in (28).

4.5. Fragments in Igbo

Fragmentary utterances exist in Igbo. Speakers of Igbo often answer a question with a phrase or a fragment, rather than with full sentences. The fragmentary utterances can be DPs, PPs or VPs. Consider the examples below.

29. Q: a. Kèdu onye bịa-ra ebe a?
which person comePST here
'Who came here?'

b. A: Nwoke ahụ
man that
'That man'

c. Nwoke ahụ bia-ra ebe a.
Man that comePST here
'That man came here'

30. Q: a. Kèdu mgbé ọ bia-ra ebe a?
when time he comePST here
'when did he come here?'

b. A: n' ụtụtụ
in morning
'in the morning'

c. Ọ bia-ra n'ụtụtụ.
He comePST in morning
'He came in the morning'

31. Q: a. Kèdu ihe ọ chọrọ i mé?
What thing he wantPART to do
'what does he want to do?'

b. A: i ri nri
(to) eat food
'to eat (food)'

c. Ọ chọrọ i ri nri.
he wantPART to eat food
'He wants to eat (food).'

(29) to (31) started out with questions that were followed by fragmentary utterances given by natural speakers of Igbo. These fragmentary utterances in (29-31(b) are elliptical equivalents of the full sentential expressions (provided in (29-31c) for clarity). (29b to 31b) are DP, PP and VP, respectively. The speakers actually preferred the fragmentary elliptical utterances to full sentences for convenience as our data shows since the full information is recoverable from context. Also, observe that all the questions that attracted the fragmentary answers all began with the *Kèdu Interrorgative.* This is consistent with Igbo as all the wh-questions are achievable with *kèdu interrorgative.* See (Nwakwegwu 2015) and (Nweya 2018).

Furthermore, Igbo, shows some connectivity effects like morphological case marking and binding effects with the full-sentence correlates of the fragment elliptical expressions. This suggests that such utterances can be analysed as deletion process at PF preceded by focus movement of the remnant fragments. This also proves that fragmentary utterances are full sentences with syntactic/linguistic materials that go unpronounced.

For example, morphological case marking is evident in Igbo as in (32) and (33) below where the fragment answers can only bear the same genitive and dative cases as it would bear in the sentential counterpart.

32. Q: a. Ụlọ onye ka ị gàrà?
house whose doPST you go
'whose house did you go to ?'

b A: nke Emeka
Emeka'sGEN

c. M gàrà na nke Emeka.
I goPST to Emeka'sGEN

d. * M gàrà EmekaACC
I goPST Emeka
*'I went Emeka'

33. Q: a. Onye kà ọ màrà ụrà?
Who did he givePST slap
'who did he (give a) slap?'

b. A: mụ DAT
Me DAT

c. Ọ màrà mụ ụrà.
He givePST meDAT slap
'He gave me a slap'

d. *Ọ màrà m ụrà.
He givePST I-NOM slap
* 'He gave I a slap.'

(32d) and (33d) are ungrammatical because of case mismatch between the fragmentary elliptical utterances and their full sentence answer counterparts. Observe that in (32b), the fragmentary utterance, *Nke Emeka* is in the genitive case just like the full sentence in (c) but the case in (d) is accusative and could not have been the right answer to the question. In (33b and c), *mụ* is in the dative case and is the right elliptical answer to the question asked, since it is the indirect object of the action *màrà*. Notice that it is exactly the same case that obtains in the full sentence. The nominative *m* produces ungrammaticality as seen in (d). This goes to argue for a case marking connectivity between the fragment and its full sentence counterpart and goes further to prove that fragments have full-fledged syntactic materials that are checked against the E-Feature and deleted.

In addition, fragmentary utterances also show binding effects with their sentence counterparts in Igbo. (34) below shows that violation of Principle B produces ungrammaticality.

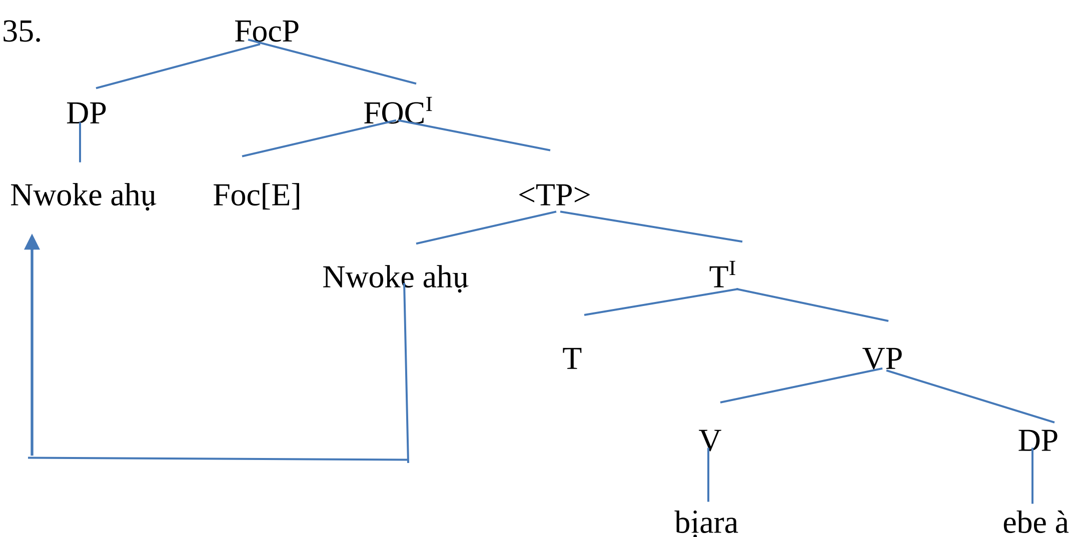
34. Q: a. Onye ka Emeka$_I$ jụrụ àjụjụ?
Who INTER Emeka askPST question
'who did Emeka ask a question?'

b. *yà$_I$
*her$_I$

c. * Emeka$_I$ jụrụ ya$_I$ àjụjụ.
'*Emeka$_I$ asked her$_I$ a question.'

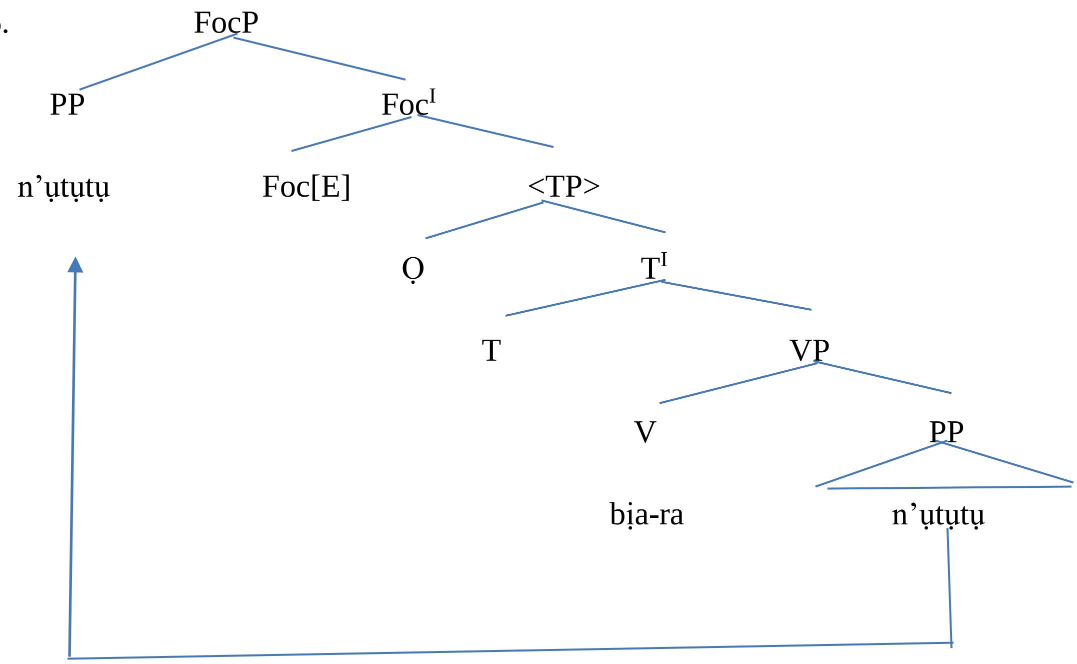
Fragment ellipsis is licensed in Igbo. Recall that Merchant (2004) had provided that the E-Feature be hosted on the Focus head to trigger the deletion of the sister TP. This TP is the full sentential correlate of the elliptical fragmentary utterance. This fragment answer is, prior to the deletion of its host, moved to FocP by A-bar focus movement. See section **4.4.1.** The diagram configurations of this process for (29 and 30b) above are in (35) and (36) below.

35.



In the above configuration, the remnant fragment DP *nwoke ahụ* is moved to FocP prior to the deletion of the remaining materials that went unpronounced in the derivation.

36.



In (36) above, the remnant PP *n'ụtụtụ* undergoes the same focus movement to FocP before the deletion of the TP.

4.6. Contrastive statement

Fragment ellipsis is attested in both languages with exactly the same licensing conditions. The data have shown that speakers of both English and Igbo make fragmentary utterances whose meaning are dependent on context. Both languages also showed evidence of the connectivity effects like morphological case marking and binding effects between the fragmentary utterances and their full sentence correlates. This goes to prove the presence of syntactic materials in the fragments answers that go unpronounced at PF. Both languages also showed that the fragment responses can be DPs, VPs or PPs.

4.7. NP Ellipsis in English

Referred to sometimes as argument ellipsis or DP ellipsis in the literature, NP Ellipsis explores situations of arguments that lack prosodic realization at PF. What has come to be known as DPs were formerly just NPs in the earlier models of generative syntax. The NP is composed of determiners and nouns with the determiner occupying the specifier positions of NPs. Words like *the, this, that, a, an* etc. were such determiners. Other categories like possessives, numeral, quantifiers, etc. also occupied these determiner positions. See the illustrations below.

37.

The above diagrams show that NPs dominate and opens up to two daughter nodes: the determiner and the noun while the DP opens up to a determiner and an NP.

38. a. determiner in [Spec, NP]: [NP the [N' [pencil] N]]

b. possessive pronoun in [Spec, NP]: [NP his [N' [pencil]N]]

c. possessor phrases in [Spec, NP]: [NP the boy's [N' [pencil]N]]

The case for DP hypothesis was proposed in Abney (1987). The study argued that DPs should be seen as universally present in all languages and as such, determiners occupy the head of a functional category D. That would imply that (38a) will be seen as (39) below.

39. [DP [the]Det [NP [pencil]N]]

The study further argues that many languages show the same manner of agreement configuration in both the nominal domain and clausal domain. So, for Abney's (1987) DP Hypothesis, the D is the nominal equivalent of INFL. Consider the examples below for illustration.

40. a. [DP POSS [det]$_{D}$ [NP [pencil]$_{N}$]]

b. [IP SUBJ [Aux]$_{I}$ [VP [swim]$_{V}$]]

In essence, both DP and NP have been used interchangeably by scholars in the literature. In this study, NP ellipsis will be the same as nominal ellipsis or the kind of ellipsis that happens in the DP domain of derivations. To highlight, nominal ellipsis was first mentioned in Ross (1967) for English. They are structures in which the null nominal follows certain prenominal modifiers and there is a phonologically overt antecedent.

41. a. **Ten students attended the play** but *six* ~~students~~ *left disappointed*.

b. **I like Bill's yellow shirt**, but *not Max's* ~~yellow shirt~~.

c. **The students that Peter invited attended the play** but *most/some/all* ~~students that Peter invited~~ *went home disappointed*.

(Ntelitheos 2003:7)

In (41a), the elided noun *students* is preceded by a numeral modifier head *six* which licensed the deletion of its complement *students*. Observe that the deleted noun, *students* is phonologically overt in the antecedent (the bold-typed clauses), what Merchant (2001) refers to as *e-givenness.* In (41b), a possessive *Max's* is in front of the noun *yellow shirt* which was eventually elided with a recoverable antecedent. Notice that (41b) and (41c) have an elided material that was larger than the nominal head to include adjectives and embedded clauses.

4.7.1. Licensing of NP ellipsis in English

In the literature, it is assumed that the rich morphology carried by the remnant modifier is the licensing mechanism. This has been demonstrated in languages to show that only definite or specific NPs can be elided and this is indicated on the morphology of the remnant modifier. These remnant modifiers express case, number, gender, and person features.

To license ellipsis using the E-Feature, Gengel (2007) proposes that the E-Feature be placed directly on the head of the focus projection to delete the complement. It can also be placed on the NP itself. The remnant modifier (quantifiers, numerals, possessives, demonstratives) moves to SpecFocP since it is focused. This is referred to as Focus Projection in DP. See the examples below.

42.a. **John like his mother** and *Bill also likes his.* ~~*mother*~~

43.a. **John saw three students yesterday** and *Bill saw five.* ~~students~~

44.a. **Jill rides Jim's bike** and *John rides Jun's* ~~car~~.

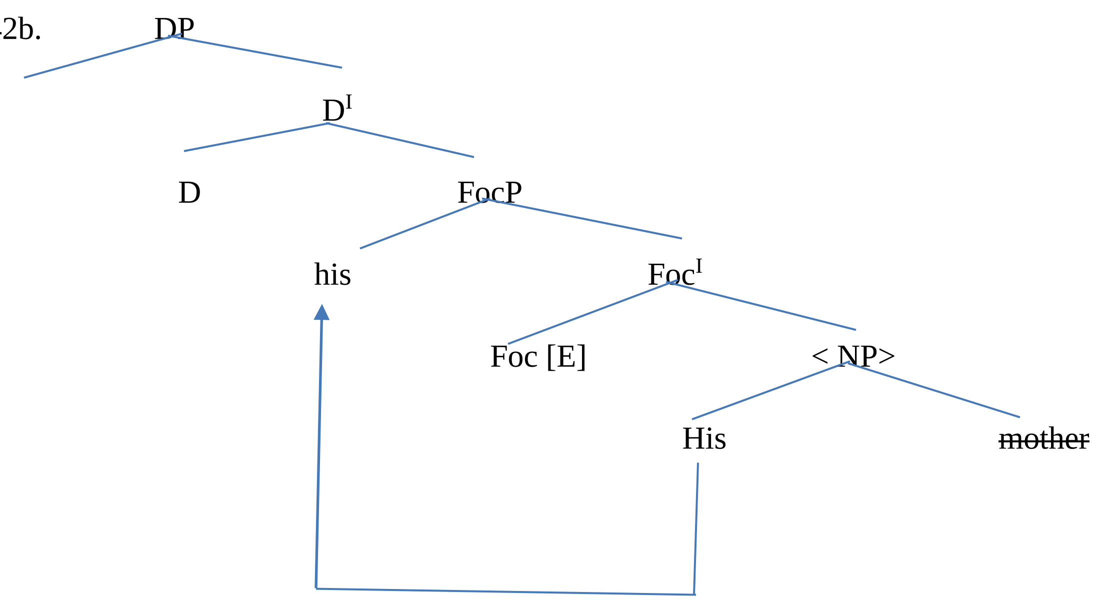
45a. **I have a green bike** and *you have a red* ~~bike~~ *one*. (*one insertion*)

46a. **The blue car is Naomi's car** and *the red one is Jane's* ~~car~~.

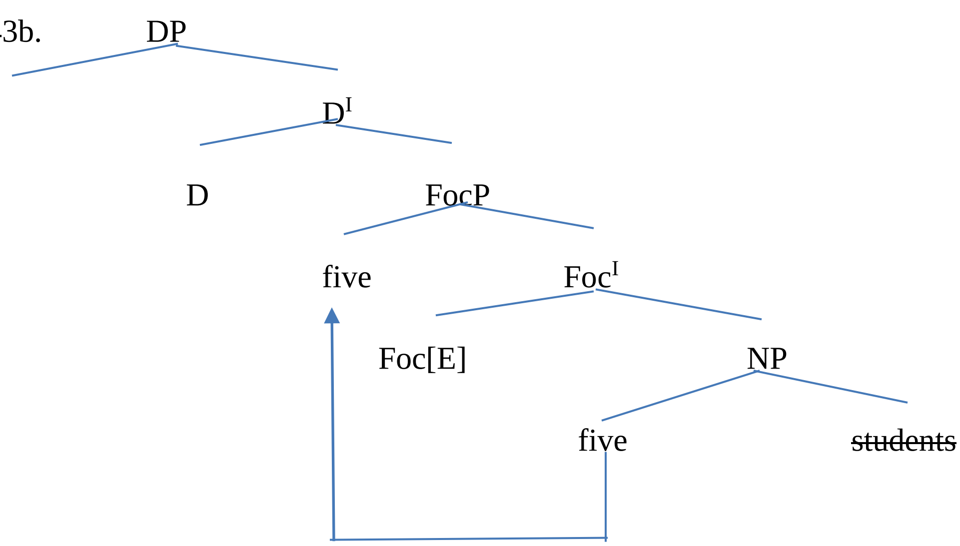
(Gengel, 2007: 16)

The DP layer of (42a), (43a) and (44a) are shown in the configuration below.

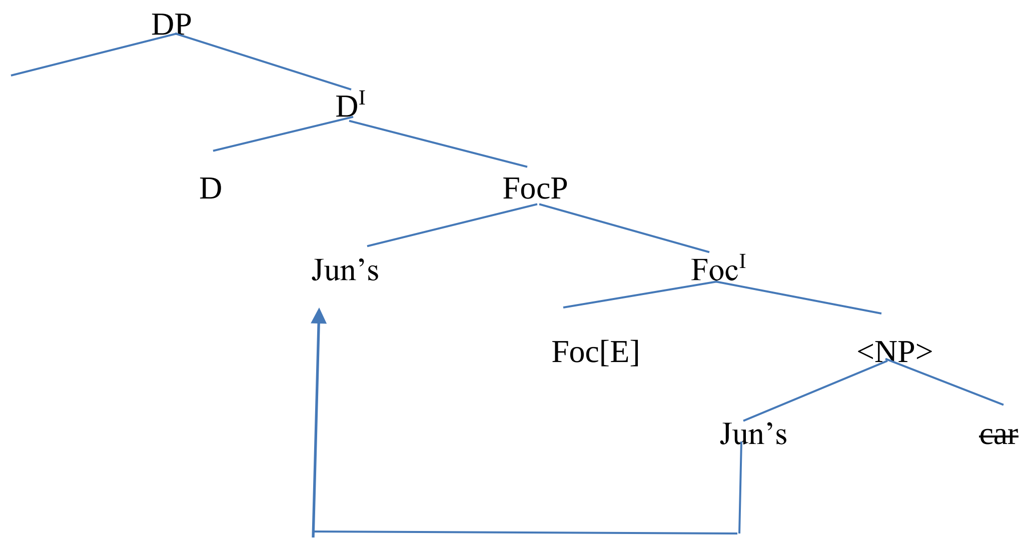
42b.



43b.



44b.



Observe that in the configurations above the E-Feature was placed on Focus head to trigger deletion of the sister NPs, the nouns, *mother*, *students and car* whose meaning had been in the context, were deleted in the conjuncts. The remnant modifiers *his* (possessive) *five* (numeral) and *Jun's* (possessive) that licensed their deletions were moved to SpecFocP where they were focused.

It is important to add that not all quantifiers license NP ellipsis in English. While quantifiers like *most*, *many*, *all*, *some*, etc can license ellipsis, *every* and *no* do not allow for NP ellipsis. See the example below.

47. Some men are decent...

    a. … but most ~~men~~ are not.

    b. …but many ~~men~~ are not.

    c. … but all ~~men~~ are not.

    d. * …but every ~~men~~ is not.

    e. * … but no ~~men~~ is not.

(Lopez 2000:190)

It can therefore be concluded that while some remnant modifiers can license NP ellipsis in English, others, as the examples in (47 d-e) show, cannot license ellipsis.

4.8. NP Ellipsis in Igbo

NP ellipsis is attested in Igbo. Igbo has pronominal modifiers numerals, demonstratives, possessives and quantifiers that precede the noun heads and hence license ellipsis of such noun heads as long as there is a phonologically overt antecedent.

To license NP ellipsis in Igbo, we follow Gengel's (2007) proposal that that the E-Feature be places on Focus head where it will subsequently delete the complement NP. Since the remnant modifier is focused, it is moved to SpecFocP. However, the DP in Igbo shows some troubling irregularities in head directionality. Most determiners (in this case, remnant modifiers) are usually in the phrase-final position and not the usual head-initial position like English. Recall that in Abney (1987), the head of the DP is the D in the initial position, but this is not the case in Igbo. Examples.

48. Nwoke à 'This man'
[Man DET]

49. Mmadụ iri 'Ten persons'
[persons DET]

50. ji ndị a 'These yams'
[yam these]

However, in other instances, Igbo shows head-first directionality in some quantifier heads and their complements as that which obtains in English. And yet again, others show head final position.

Examples:

51. ụfọdụ ụmụaka 'some children'
[DET children]

52. ọtụtụ ụmụnwanyị 'many women'
[DET woman]

53. ụmụnwanyị ole na ole 'few women'
[women few]

54. mmadụ niile 'all persons'
[person DET]

However, the assumption that Igbo is head-initial despite the inconsistencies observed above will still be pursued in this study as this irregularity is seen as a surface identity instantiated by movement. The LF is consistent with head directionality. To corroborate, we invoke Kayne's (1994) Linear Correspondence Axiom (LCA) which stipulates a uniform, universal word order, now taken as part of UG. The Linear Correspondence Axiom holds that:

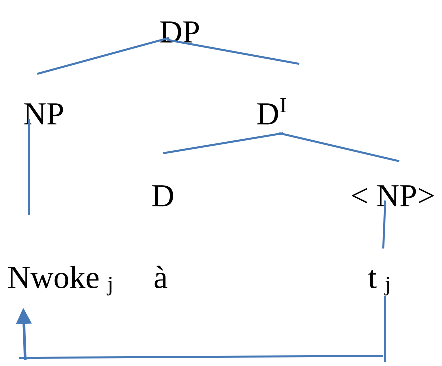
a. The head precedes the complement.

b. The specifier precedes the head.

c. Spec > Head > Complement (Kayne, 1994:35)

Kayne (1994) believes this to be a universal configuration for all structures irrespective of possible complexities or irregularities. The scrambled head-specifier-complement order we see on the surface are instantiated by movements. To show this using a phrase marker, observe the Logical Form of (48) presented in (55) below.

55. Nwoke à



In the analysis that will follow subsequently, we will show that NP ellipsis happened after movement had taken place from the DP complement to SpecDP in the Igbo examples that have head final DP feature.

56.a. **Mmadụ iri gàrà agbamakwụkwọ ahụ** mànà ~~mmadụ~~ *ise erighi nri.*

Persons ten goPST wedding the but ~~persons~~ five do-eatPSTNEG food
'Ten person attended the wedding but *five* didn't eat.'

57a **Ụmụnwanyị ahụ siri nri** mànà ~~ụmụnwanyị~~ *olé na olé esighi nke ọma.*
Women those cookPST food but women few cookNEGPST well
'Those women cooked food but *few* didn't cook well.'

58a. **Emeka kpọrọ ọtụtụ mmadu** mànà *sọsọ ụfọdụ* ~~mmadụ~~ *zàrà*.
Emeka callPST many persons but only some ~~persons~~ answerPST
'Emeka called many persons but only *some* answered.'

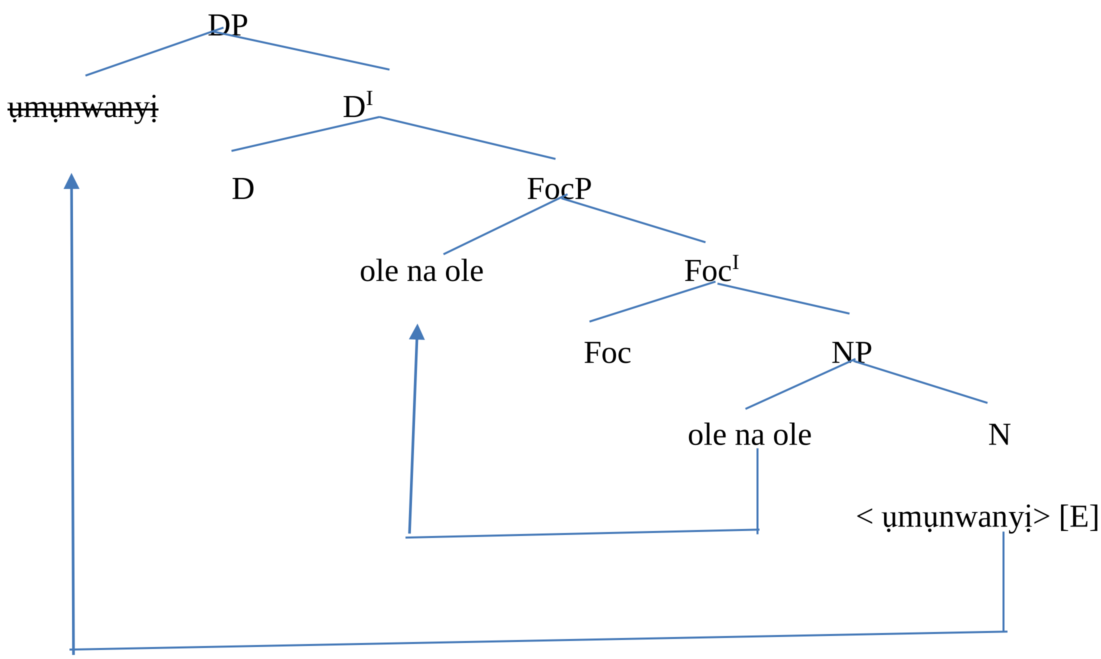
59a **Mary achọghị akwukwọ ndị ahụ** mànà *ọ chọrọ* ~~akwụkwọ~~ *ndị à.*
Mary do3PSNEG-wantPERFASP book those but she want3PS ~~books~~ these
'Mary doesn't want those books but she wants *these.*'

60a. Ụgbọala oji à bụ nke Emeka mànà ~~ụgbọala~~ nke ọcha à bụ nke Mary.
Car black this BE POSS Emeka but ~~car~~ *one* white the BE POSS Mary
'This black car is Emeka's car while the white one is Mary's'

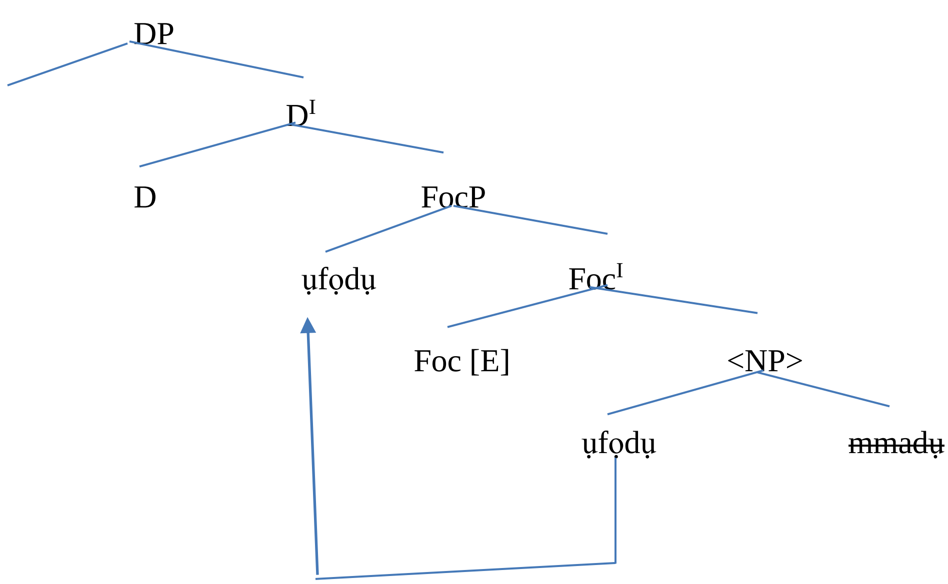
61a. *Ọ kpọrọ ụmụazi oku mànà ~~ụmụazi~~ niile abiaghị.
S/he summonPST children BEN but ~~children~~ all comeNEG-PST
'S/he summoned the children but all didn't come.'

In (56a.), the numeral DP remnant modifier *ise* licensed the deletion of the NP *mmadụ* since this NP is recoverable from the antecedent clause. Notice, however, that the head of the DP *ise* is derived after the complement *mmadụ* due to the head-final position variations in Igbo DPs. In (57a), the quantifier remnant modifier, *ole na ole* also parses the omission of the noun *ụmụnwanyị*. Observe that in (58a), the head directionality in the DP is consistent with the English head-initial position where the quantifier remnant determiner head *ụfọdụ and ọtụtụ* are derived before their complements NP *mmadụ.* The D head in the ellipsis site *ụfọdụ* permits the deletion of its complement *mmadụ.* The demonstrative *ndị à* licenses the deletion of *akwụkwọ* in (59a) and the possessive marker *nke* does same in (60a). In the same (60a) also, the process of *one insertion* is made with *nke* for agreement features with the adjective *ocha.* (61a) is ungrammatical. The quantifier *niile* cannot license ellipsis in Igbo. There has to always be a nominal complement for it to have meaning in the language. The DP phases of (57a), (58a) and (59a) are shown in the configurations below.

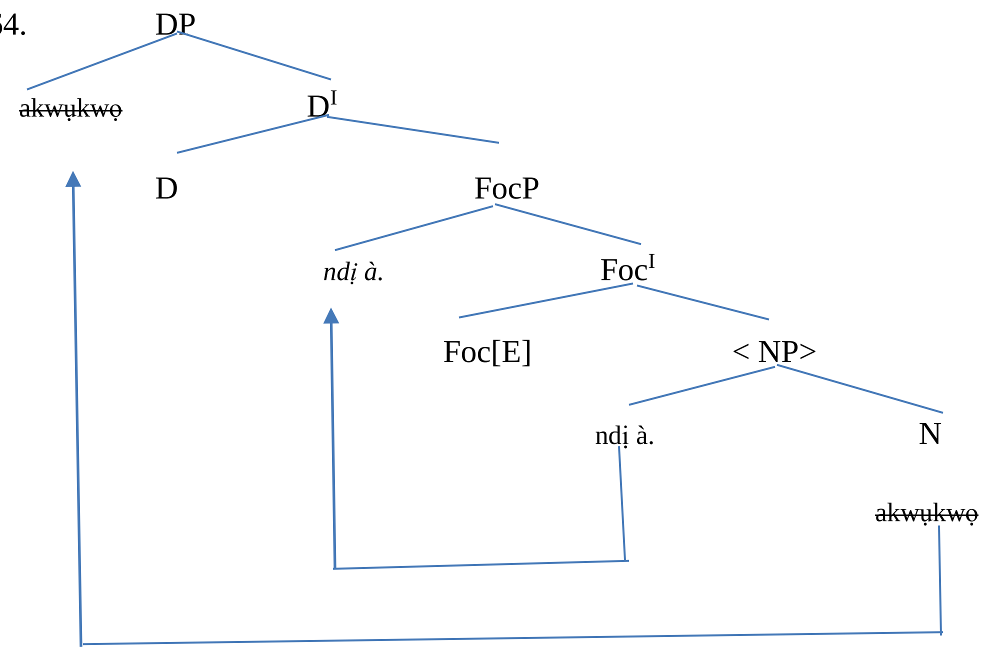
62.



63.



64.



The data and configurations provided above have accounted for NP ellipsis in Igbo with its deletion process.

4.9. Contrastive statement

NP ellipsis is attested in English and Igbo. The remnant modifiers like demonstrative, possessives, numeral and quantifiers, rich in morphology, can license the ellipsis of their complements in Igbo and English. English, however, showed that all the quantifiers cannot license ellipsis. The quantifiers *every* and *no* are examples. Igbo showed a variation in head directionality. Some determiner heads are initial while others are final. This did not affect the deletion process though as studies have proven that this is a surface identity. Igbo also showed that the quantifier *niile* cannot license ellipsis.

Conclusion

This chapter has examined VP-ellipsis, Fragment ellipsis and NP- ellipsis in English and Igbo. It is evident that all the selected ellipsis types are attested in English and Igbo. Findings, however, show some similarities and differences in the ways the licensing conditions of these ellipsis types operate. This is consistent with the expectations of Contrastive Analysis. These findings and conclusions will be highlighted more in the next chapter.

CHAPTER 5

SUMMARY AND CONCLUSION

5.0. Introduction

This chapter provides the summary of the study, findings, hierarchy of difficulties that may be faced by Igbo learners of English and suggests solutions to such predictions of difficulties.

5.1. Summary of the study

This study has interrogated and examined VP ellipsis, Fragment ellipsis and NP-ellipsis in English and Igbo. Focus was on the similarities and differences in the licensing conditions that exist among these selected elliptical structures. The study examines these licensing conditions with a view to discovering the learning difficulties that may be encountered by Igbo learners of English in Nigeria. These difficulties are assumed to be orchestrated by the differences that exist in the elliptical structures of the two languages. To establish the need for a contrastive study between English and Igbo elliptical structures, the study examines the relationship between the two languages in Chapter 1. It shed some insight into the two languages and the functions they perform in Nigeria's linguistic landscape. Thereafter, the next chapter reviewed relevant literature. This includes conceptual and empirical studies. It engages the nature and structure of elliptical structures and some of the debates on their syntax and semantic identity. Some empirical studies like Ntelitheos (2004), Corver and van Koppen (2006) Algryani (2012) and Bevis (2018) were reviewed and their findings were summarized. Analysis in this study, as it is highlighted in this same chapter, is driven using Merchant's (2001) E-Feature within the framework and provisions of the Minimalist Program. Chapter 3 provides the method of data collection and analysis while Chapter 4 presented and analysed the data from the selected elliptical structures guided by Merchant's E-Feature as provided in the MP. The next sections provides the findings from the study.

5.2. Findings

The major area of difference in the licensing conditions of VP ellipsis in English and Igbo is that in English, auxiliaries and modals are independently hosted on head T and the lexical verbs on the ʋP or VP domains and hence ensuring that the auxiliaries check and delete the linguistic materials in the v/VP domain. However, this does not obtain in Igbo. Auxiliaries, discourse linkers and lexicals are conflated or merged in an obligatory manner such that while the auxiliaries license the deletion of the VP constituents, it merges with the lexical on head T. This implies that only the remaining materials in the VP domain get deleted while all the items on T head move to spell out.

Furthermore, speakers of English and Igbo both make fragmentary utterances like DPs, VPs and PPs instead of full-fledged TPs. The meaning of these fragmentary utterances are dependent on context, however. Both languages show connectivity effects to prove that fragmentary utterances are grammatically dependent on their full sentential counterparts. These dependencies are seen in rich morphological case marking, preposition stranding, binding effects, islands, complementizer deletions, polarity items, raising and pronominals. It show that violation of these connectivity effects produced ungrammaticality. Licensing in fragment ellipsis is exactly in Igbo as it is in English. The fragmentary utterances are treated as remnants of TP deletion by being maximally projected out of the ellipsis through a focus movement or functional projection.

Finally, NP ellipsis is richly attested in English and Igbo. Remnant modifiers like demonstratives, possessives, numerals and quantifiers show that they can license the deletion of NPs in the DP domain of the ellipsis sites. To license these deletions, the E-Feature is placed on the head of projection where it triggers the deletion of the NP constituents. Prior to this deletion, the modifier is maximally projected to Spec FocP. However, English shows that quantifiers like *every* and *no* cannot license NP ellipsis. Deleting their NP complements results in ungrammaticality. Igbo, conversely, shows variation in head directionality of some DPs. Some determiners or remnant modifiers are in head-final position instead of the head-initial position that obtains in English. This is however argued as a surface identity instantiated by movement. Igbo also shows that the quantifier *niile* cannot license the deletion of its NP complement. A nominal complement has to always be present for *niile* to have meaning.

Consequently, we predict that Igbo-English learners may encounter some of the learning difficulties discussed in the next section.

5. 3. Hierarchy of difficulties

Due to the divergences observed between the features of English and Igbo VP-ellipsis, Igbo learners of English may encounter difficulties with constructing VP ellipsis structures or even understanding such structures in written or spoken discourse situations. This is because in the English VP elliptical structures, all the materials in the VP domain get deleted leaving only the auxiliaries while it does not obtain this way in Igbo. So, the Igbo, being affected by negative transfer, may likely produce awkward English expressions with redundant lexical verbs in the ellipsis site like *John was arrested in London and Bill was arrested in London too* instead of a more precise and convenient *John was arrested in London and Bill was too* because in Igbo VP ellipsis, the lexical verb is pronounced. It is also likely that in written discourses in English where VP ellipsis has been used, the Igbo learner of English may have difficulties understanding such structures since they do not occur like that in Igbo and hence cannot be distinguished by him/her.

The English language teacher can tackle this problem by clearly spelling out the way the verb system/inflectional system in Igbo differs from that of English and how these differences affect VP ellipsis in both languages.

Furthermore, the study predicts that Igbo learners of English may not encounter any problems with fragmentary utterances in English since its features are exactly like what obtains for them in Igbo. The teacher should, however, emphasize the need for the Igbo learners to be careful with the construction of fragmentary utterances to ensure that they are short grammatical equivalents of the full-fledged sentences showing all connectivity effects to avoid ungrammaticality.

Also, the differences discovered in the NP ellipsis of both languages may have some implications on language learning. The Igbo learner of English may encounter difficulties with head directionality in English since English is constantly head-initial and Igbo is head-initial sometimes and head-final at other times. This can lead to difficulty in knowing the exact option available to the Igbo learners of English, thereby resulting in errors. The English language teacher has to emphasize this critically. Also, since *every* and *no* cannot license ellipsis in English, the Igbo learner has to be informed so as not to produce ungrammatical sentences **no died* instead of *no person died. Niile* is another quantifier that has to be emphasized as capable of producing ungrammatical sentences if negatively transferred from English since it can license ellipsis in English but cannot in Igbo. The Igbo user of English has to be aware of this.

5.4. Conclusion

This study is in the purview of Contrastive Analysis. It has pursued the need to compare and contrast VP ellipsis, fragments and NP ellipsis in English and Igbo with a view to tracking and exploring their licensing conditions. The study has applied Merchant's (2001) E-Feature as provided within the framework of the MP to drive analysis. Thus, the study identified that aforementioned ellipsis types are attested in both languages with some peculiar permutations here and there. The study has highlighted some difficulties that Igbo learners may encounter with English as a result of these variations. Possible suggestions have also been made to these predictions.

References

Abney, S. 1987. The English noun phrase in its sentential aspect. Ph.D. Thesis. Linguistics. MIT. xiii+350.

Achebe, C. 1984. Editorial and linguistic problems in Aka weta: a comment. *Ụwa Ndi Igbo 1*. 94- 95.

Adegbite, W. 2010. *English language usage, uses and misuse(s) in a non-host second language context, Nigeria:* An inaugural lecture delivered at the Oduduwa Hall, Obafemi Awolowo University, Ile-Ife, Nigeria on Tuesday, September 14, 2010. Ile-Ife, Nigeria: Obafemi Awolowo University Press.

Adenyaju, D. 2004. *The English language: yesterday and today.* University of Ibadan Distance Learning Centre.

Adetugbo, A. 1978. The Development of English in Nigeria up to 1914: A socio-historical appraisal. *Journal of the Historical Society of Nigeria*. 9.2: 89-103.

Aelbrecht, L. 2010. *The syntactic licensing of ellipsis.* Amsterdam: John Benjamins

Aiyeomoni, M.O. 2012. The Languages in Nigerian Socio-Political Domains: Features and Functions. *English Language Teaching* 5.10: 12-19.

Akindele, F. and Adegbite, W. 2005. *The sociology and politics of English in Nigeria: an introduction.* Ife: OAU Press.

Akporokah, J.O. 2018. A historical overview of the English Language: roles and problems. *Academic Scholarship*.Retrieved Nov. 8, 2021, from https://www.globalacademicgroup.com/journals/academic%20scholarship/A%20HISTRICAL% 20OVERVIEW%20OF%20THE%20ENGLISH.pdf

Algryani, A. 2012. The syntax of ellipsis in Libyan Arabic: a generative analysis of sluicing, VP ellipsis, stripping, and negative contrast. PhD. Thesis. Linguistics. Arts. University of Newcastle. xi+175.

Ali, N. 2007. Machine translation: a contrastive linguistic perspective. http://www.unesco.org/comnat/france/ali.htm.Rtrd.22/11/2021.

Araromi, M.O. 2018. Language policy implementation in multilingual Nigeria: French and mother-tongue experience. *AFRREV LALIGENS: An International Journal of Language, Literature and Gender Studies*7.1: 94-102.

Arregui, A., Clifton, Jr., C., Frazier, L., and Moulton, K. 2006. Processing elided verb phrases with flawed antecedents: The Recycling Hypothesis. *Journal of Memory and Language.* 55.2:232–246.

Baker, C. 2001. *Foundations of bilingual education and bilingualism.* Clevedon. Multilingual Matters

Banjo, L.A. 1996. *Making a virtue of necessity: An overview of the English language in Nigeria.* Ibadan: Ibadan University Press.

Barber, 1999. *The English language: a historical introduction.* England: Cambridge University Press.

Baugh, C. and Cable, T. 1978. *A history of the English language.* London: Routledge.

Bevis, A. 2018. A comparative study of selected ellipsis constructions in English and isiZulu. MA. Proj. Department of Linguistics. University of KwaZulu Nata, Howard College, South Africa. vi+161.

Black, C. 1998. A step-by-step introduction to the Government and Binding theory of syntax. Retrieved Feb. 10, 2022, from http://www.sil.org/america/mexico/ling/E002-IntroGB.pdf

Blench, R. 2012. *An atlas of Nigerian languages* (3rd ed.). Cambridge: Kay Williamson Educational Foundation.

Brice, A.E., and Brice, R.G. 2009. *Language development: monolingual and bilingual Acquisition.* Boston. Pearson Education Inc.

Brown, E. and Miller, J. 1985. *Syntax: A linguistic introduction to sentence structure.* Hutchinson & Co. publishers Ltd, London.

Chomsky, N. 1965. *Aspects of the theory of syntax.* Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.

----------. 1986. *Knowledge of language: its nature, origin and use*. Westport, Connecticut and London: Praeger.

----------. 1993. A minimalist program for linguistic theory. Eds. Hale, K. and Keyser, J. *The View from Building 20: Essays in honour of Sylvain Bromberger*. Massachusetts: MIT Press. 1-52.

----------. 1995. *Minimalist program*. Cambridge, MA: MIT press.

----------. 2000. Minimalist inquiries: The framework. Eds. Martin, R. Michaels, D. and Uriagereka, J. *Step by step: Essays in minimalist syntax in honor of Howard Lasnik*. Massachusetts: MIT Press. 89-115.

----------. 2008. On phases. Eds. Freidin, R. Otero, C. and Luisa, M. Zubizarreta. *Foundational issues in linguistic theory*. Cambridge, Massachusetts: MIT Press. 133-166.

----------. 2013. Problems of Projection. *Lingua* 130: 33-49.

----------. 2015. *The minimalist program* (20th Anniversary ed.) Massachusetts: MIT Press.

Chomsky, N. & Lasnik, H. 1993. Principles and parameters theory. Eds. Jacobs, J. von Stechow, A., Sternefield, W. and Vannemann, T. *Syntax: An international handbook of contemporary research.* Berlin: de Gruyter. 506-569.

Christopherson, P. 1953. Some special West African English Words. *English Studies,* 35. 67-71.

Citko, B. 2014. *Phase theory: an introduction.* London. Cambridge University Press.

Collins, C. 2016. Introduction to minimalist syntax. *African Linguistics school* 4 unpublished lecture notes. Yamoussoukro, Ivory Coast

Cook, V. and Newson, M. 2007. *Chomsky's universal grammar: An introduction*. Malden: Blackwell.

Corder, S. 1974. Idiosyncratic dialects and error analysis. Ed.Richard, J. *Error analysis: Perspectives on second language acquisition.* Essex: Longman. 158-171.

Corver, N and van Koppen, M. 2006. Let's focus on noun ellipsis. *Glow: Universitat Auomena de Barcelona.*

Crystal, D. 1992. *An encyclopedic dictionary of language and languages.* USA: Black well Publishing.

----------. 2003. *A dictionary of linguistics and phonetics*. 5th Ed. Oxford: Blackwell Publishing.

Culicover, P. and Jackendoff, R. 2005. *Simpler syntax*. Oxford: Oxford University Press

Dalrymple, M., Shieber, M. and Pereira, F. 1991. Ellipsis and higher-order unification. *Linguistics and Philosophy,* 14.4:399–452.

Di Pietro, R. 1971. *Language structures in contrast.* Newbury House, Rowley, Mass.

Drout, M.C. 2006. *The modern scholar.* Recorded Books: LLC.

Ekpe, M. 2007. Standard Nigerian English: A stable variety in Emerging Evolution of World Englishes. *Journal of the Nigerian English Studies Association.* 12. 69-80.

Emenanjo, E. 1978. *Elements of modern Igbo grammar*. Ibadan: University Press.

----------. 1979. Some aspects of interrogation in Igbo. *Kiabàrà* II:102- 112.

----------. 2015. *A grammar of contemporary Igbo: Constituents, features and processes*. Port Harcourt: M & J Grand Orb.

Emenanjo, E. N., Ndimele, O., Ohiri-Aniche, C., Ogbonna, J., Onwumah, A. C., Aimenwauu, N., Ujah, C., Eme, A. C and Okuma 2011. *A unified standard orthography for the Igbo language cluster.* Cape Town: The Centre for Advanced Studies of African Society and the Centre for Black and African Arts and Civilization. Monograph No 242.

Erschler, D. 2018. Typology of bizarre ellipsis varieties. Ph.D Thesis submitted to the University of Massachusetts, Amherst. xiii+241.

Fiengo, R. and May, R. 1994. *Indices and Identity*. Cambridge MA: The MIT Press.

Fries, C. 1945. *Teaching and learning English as a foreign language.* Ann Avbor: University of Michigan Press.

Gengel, K. 2007. Focus and ellipsis: A generative analysis of pseudogapping and other elliptical structures. PhD. Thesis. Department of Linguistics. University of Stuttgart. xiii+304.

Goldberg, L. 2005. Verb-stranding VP ellipsis: A cross-linguistic study. PhD. Thesis. Linguistics. McGill University. Canada. xi+215.

Halliday, M. and Hasan, R.1976. *Cohesion in English.* Longman. London.

Hanes, J. 2012. English: various accents of the British Isles. From http://www.englishwithjohn.net. Retrieved 20/11/22.

Hankamer, J. 1979. Deletion in coordinate structures. PhD. Thesis. Linguistics. Yale. vi+431.

Hardt, D. 1993. Verb Phrase Ellipsis: Form, Meaning and Processing. PhD. Thesis. Linguistics. University of Pennsylvania. vii+133.

Haruna, H.H. 2017. Linguistic Diversity and Language Engenderment: Towards the Revitalisation of Bole Language in Nigeria. *International Journal For Innovative Research in Multidisciplinary*. 13.10:108-113

Ikekeonwu, C. I., Ezikeojiaku P. A., Ubani A. & Ugoji J. 1999. *Fọnọlọji na grama Ìgbò.* Ibadan: University Press.

James, C. 1980. *Contrastive analysis.* London: Longman**.**

Johnson, K. 2008a. Introduction. Ed. Johnson, K. *Topics in Ellipsis.* Cambridge University Press. Cambridge. 1-14.

Johnson, K. 2008b. The view of QR from ellipsis. In Johnson, K. ed. *Topics in ellipsis.* New York: Cambridge University Press. 69 - 94.

Jowitt, D. 1991. *Nigerian English usage: An Introduction.* Lagos: Longman Nigeria.

Kayne, R. S. 1994. *The antisymmetry of syntax.* Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.

……….. 2013. Comparative syntax. *Lingua* 130:132-151.

Kehler, A. 2000. Coherence and the resolution of ellipsis. *Linguistics and Philosophy,* 23.6:533–575.

Kennedy,C. 2003. Ellipsis and syntactic representation. Eds. Shwabe, K. & Winker, S. *Interface: deriving and interpreting omitted structures.* Amsterdam: John Benjamins. 29-54.

Kertz, L. 2010. Ellipsis reconsidered. Ph.D. Thesis. Linguistics. University of Carlifonia. xiii+139.

Kratzer, A. 1995. Stage-level and individual-level predicates as inherent generics. Eds. Carlson, G. N., and Pelletier, F. J. *The Generic Book.* Chicago: University of Chicago Press. 125-175.

Krifka, M. 2006. Association with focus phrase. Ed. Molnar, V and Winkler, S. *The architecture of focus.* Berlin: Mounton de Gruyter, 137-168.

Lado, R. 1957. *Linguistics across culture.* Ann Arbor: University of Nichgan Press.

Lamidi, M. T. 2008. *Aspects of Chomskyan grammar.* Ibadan. University Press PLC.

Lasnik, H. 1995. Case and expletives revisited: On greed and other human failings. *Linguistic inquiry*, 26. 615-633.

………. 1995a. A Note on Pseudogapping. *Papers on Minimalist Syntax. MIT Working Papers in Linguistics* 27. 143-163.

………. 1995b. Verbal morphology: Syntactic Structures meets the minimalist program. Eds. Hector, C. and Paula, Kempchinsky. *Evolution and Revolution in Linguistic Theory: Essays in Honor of Carlos Otero.* Georgetown University. 251-257.

……….. 1999a. Pseudogapping puzzles. Eds. Lappin, S and Benmamoun, B. *Fragments: Studies in Ellipsis and Gapping.* Oxford University Press. 141-174.

……….. 1999b. On Feature Strength: Three Minimalist Approaches to Overt Movement. *Linguistic Inquiry* 30.2: 197-217.

----------. 2001.When can you save a structure by destroying it? *In Proceedings of North Eastern linguistics society 31*. Eds. Kim, N. & Strauss, U. 301-320. Amherst, MA: GLSA

----------. 2005. Grammar, levels and typology. Ed. McGilvary, J. *Chomsky*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. 81-93.

----------. 2006. On ellipsis: Is material that is phonetically absent but semantically present present or absent syntactically? Paper presented at 22nd Scandinavian Conference of Linguistics, University of Aalborg. Retrieved9.02.2012 from: http://ling.umd.edu/~lasnik/Lasnik%20manuscripts/Lasnik%20Denmark%20 ms%20A4.pdf.

----------. 2007. *On ellipsis: the PF approach to missing constituents.* University of Maryland working papers in Linguistics.

Lee, W, R. 1968. Thoughts of contrastive linguistics in the context of foreign language teaching. Ed. Alatis, J. 1968. Contrastive Linguistics and its pedagogical Indications. Washington: D.C. George Town University.

Lin, F. Y. 2015. What is really wrong with universal grammar? *Language* 91. 2: e27-e30

Lobeck, A. 1995. *Ellipsis: Functional heads, licensing, and identification.* Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Lopez, L. 1999. Ellipsis and discourse linking. *Lingua.* 110. 2002. 183-213.

Longobardi, G. 2018. Principles, parameters, and schemata: A radically underspecified UG. *Linguistic Analysis.* 517-557.

Lyons, J. 1977. *Semantics 2*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

----------. 1989. *Introduction to theoretical linguistics.* New York: Cambridge University Press.

Manetta, E. 2018. Verb-phrase ellipsis and complex predicates in Hindi-Urdu. Nat Lang Linguist Theory https://doi.org/10.1007/s11049-018-9429-9.

Matthews, P. 2007. *Oxford concise dictionary of linguistics*. Oxford University Press, Oxford.

Mbah, B. M. and Mbah. E. E. 2010. Topics in phonetics and phonology: Contribution from Ìgbò. Nsukka: AP Express.

Merchant, J. 2001. *The syntax of silence: Sluicing, islands, and the theory of ellipsis*. New York: Oxford University Press.

………. 2004. Fragment and ellipsis. *Linguistic and philosophy.* 27. 661-738.

……….2007. An asymmetry in voice mismatches in VP-ellipsis and pseudogapping. *Linguistic Inquiry.* 39.1:169-179

……….. 2008. Variable island repair under ellipsis. Eds. K. Johnson. *Topics in ellipsis. New York:* Cambridge University Press. 132-153.

……….. 2013. Voice and ellipsis. *Linguistic Inquiry*. 44.1. 77-108.

Morgan, J. 1989. Sentence Fragments Revisited. Eds. Bradley M, Randolph G, and Caroline W. *CLS 25 Parasession on Language in Context.* Chicago Linguistic Society, Chicago. 228-241.

Ndimele, O-M. 1992. *The parameters of universal grammar: A GB Approach*. Owerri: African Education Services.

Ntelitheos, D. 2004. Syntax of elliptical and discontinuous nominals. M.A. Proj. Linguistics. UCLA. vi+78.

Nwachukwu, P. A. 1985. Inherent complement verbs in Igbo. *Journal of the Linguistics Association of Nigeria (JOLAN)* 3. 61-74 .

Nwankwegu, J. A. 2015. Microparametric syntax of interrogatives in North Eastern group of Igbo dialects. PhD. Thesis. Linguistics. University of Nigeria, Nsukka, Nigeria. xvi+269.

Nwaozuzu, G. I. 2008. *Dialects of Ìgbò language.* Nsukka: University of Nigeria Press.

Nweya, G. 2018. The Igbo clause and the cartography of the complementizer phrase domain. PhD.Thesis. Department of Igbo, African and Asian studies. Nnamdi Azikiwe University, Nigeria. xi+229.

Kwokwo, M. 2012. A Morphosyntactic Investigation of Functional Categories in English and Ịzọn. PhD. Thesis. Department of English. University of Ibadan.xiii+198.

Odlin, T. 1989. *Language transfer*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Ogbo, O. 1984. Saving the Igbo language. *Ụwa ndi Igbo 1*. 103-170

Ojo, J. 1996. A contrastive lexicology of six semantic fields of English and Yoruba. MA. Proj. English. University of Ibadan. ix+96.

Omolaiye, H. 2013. A contrastive lexicology of six semantics field of English and Okpameri. MA. Proj. English. University of Ibadan.ix+81.

Oller, J. & Ziahosseiny,S. 1970. The contrastive analysis hypothesis and spelling errors. *Language Learning.* 20:2. 183-189.

Oreka, G. 2010. Language policy and educational development in Africa: The case of Nigeria.*Scottish Languages Review* 21:17-26.

Ouhalla, J. 1999. *Introducing transformational grammar: From principles and parameters to minimalism* 2nd Ed. China: Foreign Language Teaching and Research.

Oyetade, S.O. and Ekpe, M. 2010. *The English language in Nigeria.* National Open University of Nigeria.

Quirk, R. & Greenbaum, S. 1973. *A university grammar of English.* Pearson. London,

Radford, A. 2009. *An introduction to English sentence structure.* Cambridge: Cambridge

University Press

Resinger, S. M. 2009. *Quantitative research in linguistics*: An introduction. London: Continuum International Publishing Group.

Rizzi, L. 1997. The fine structure of the left periphery. Ed. L. Haegeman. *Elements of grammar: a handbook of generative syntax.* Dordrecht: Kluver.

Rooth, M. 1992a. Ellipsis redundancy and reduction redundancy. Eds. Berman, S. and Arild H. *Pro-ceedings of the Stuttgart Ellipsis Workshop.*

----------. 1992b. A theory of focus interpretation. *Natural Language Semantics* 1. 75–116.

Ross, J. R. 1967. Constraints on variables in syntax. PhD. Thesis. Linguistics. Massachusetts Institute of Technology. vi+500.

----------.1969. Guess who? Eds. Binnick, R., Davidson, A., Green, G. and Morgan, J. *Papers from the Fifth Regional Meeting of the Chicago Linguistic Society*, Chicago Linguistic Society. 225-286.

Rouledge encyclopaedia of language teaching. 1990 edition.

Sag, I. 1976. Deletion and Logical Form. PhD. Thesis. Department of Linguistics. Massachusetts Institute of Technology. x+374.

Tancredi, C. D. 1992. Deletion, deaccenting, and presupposition. PhD. Thesis. Massachusetts Institute of Technology. v+150.

Uba, M. 2006. *Ntọala usoroasụsụ Igbo.* Ibadan: Gold Press.

Udofot, I. 2007. *English and the Nigerian situation: Trends and Imperatives.* An Inaugural Lecture delivered in the University of Uyo, Uyo.

Udoh, I. 2004. Ed. *The languages of the South-East zone of Nigeria*: *A geopolitical profile.* Lagos: Concept.

Ugorji, N. 2019. Ellipsis in Ngwaa. *Journal of languages, Linguistics and Literary Studies.*

(JOLLS) 9:116-128.

Uman, A.T and Usman, B. 2017. Linguistic diversity and Nigerian languages dynamism. *Education and Science Journal of Policy Review and Curriculum Development* 7.1:66-74

Uwalaka, M. 1991. Wh-movement in Ìgbò, *UCL working papers in linguistics 3*, 185-209.

----------. 1996. *Fònọlọjì na ǹtọ̀ asụ̀ sụ Ìgbò.* Ibadan: Krafts Books.

----------. 2001. The anguish of Igbo as a mother tongue: internal and external conflicts. Ed. Igboanusi, H. *Language attitude and language conflict in West Africa.* Ibadan: Enicrowfit Publishers. 50-67.

van Craenenbroeck, J. 2010a. *The Syntax of Ellipsis: Evidence from Dutch Dialects.* Oxford: Oxford University Press.

……….. 2010b. Invisible last resort: A note on clefts as the underlying source for sluicing. *Lingua* 120: 1714–1726.

……….. 2017. VP-ellipsis. Eds. Everaert, M. and van Riemsdijk, H. *The Blackwell companion to syntax.* 2nd edition. Hoboken: Wiley-Blackwell. 1-35.

van Craenenbroeck, J. and Merchant, J. 2013. Ellipsis phenomena. Ed. den Dikken, M. *The Cambridge handbook of generative syntax.* Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. 701-745.

van Riemsdijk, H. C. 1978. *A case study in syntactic markedness: The binding nature of prepositional phrases*. Dordrecht: Foris.

Weinreich, U. 1953. *Language in contact.* The Hague: Mouton.

Williams, E. S. 1977. Discourse and logical form. *Linguistic Inquiry*. 8.1:101–139.

Wurmbrand, S. 2012. The merge condition: A syntactic approach. To appear in : Eds. Kosta, P., Schürcks, L., Franks, S. and Radev-Bork, T. *Minimalism and beyond*: *Radicalizing the interfaces.* Amsterdam: John Benjamins.

Zeuske, M. 2012. Historiography and research problems of slavery and the slave trade in a global-historical perspective. *International Review of Social History*.57. 87-111.